Participation Points

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31293236.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), if you don't have canonical aliens homemade is fine, Melog (She-Ra), Bow's Siblings (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Post-Canon, Post-Season/Series 05, Canon Compliant, 5+1 Things, POV Outsider, SO much pov outsider, IN SPACE!, glimmer is a badass, catra gets a staff, bow's family loves him but that doesn't mean they understand him, adora fights her girlfriend for educational reasons, Reverse Chronological Order, is it non-linear storytelling if it's linearly backwards?, Slice of Life, but a space shenanigans kind of life

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English

Series:
Part 5 of The Squad Goes Intergalactic (stand-alone stories)

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She-Ra Big Bang 2021

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by ForsythiaRising

Summary

Catra makes a variety of dramatic entrances, Glimmer fields a variety of dramatic interruptions, Bow's kind of a big deal, and Adora consistently fails to match expectations.

Or: they're intergalactic celebrities. Eventually.

Or: five conferences the Best Friends Squad presented at and one they attended, in reverse chronological order.

FIVE: +20 years, First Cosmic Symposium on the Restoration of Magic, Etheria

Chapter Notes

> This is for the She-Ra Anniversary Big Bang! It's an idea that's been in my drafts since literally last June, and it felt like the only thing I could possibly post to honor the one year anniversary of the finale of this show that broke my brain and made me write.
>
> This fic goes backwards in time - the first chapter is the last thing that happens chronologically, the last chapter the first, etc. - and it'll be posted in six parts. I'll put more about this on tumblr (find me @ ostensiblyarticulate), but in brief: the first and the last chapters focus on the whole Best Friends Squad (kind of), and the four in the middle each focus on one of its members (though often ft. the rest of them, and ch5 is really just The Catradora Chapter). The POV is always going to be an outsider.
>
> So here, have the chapter in which the least happens, because I just want them to have a nice life. The rest will come out one by one as I have time to edit. Please don't worry about being left hanging, because I do have it drafted in full. I'm just a picky editor.
>
> Finally, most importantly, there is absolutely lovely art for this chapter from sundropzzz (you should probably wait till after you read to look at it, because it's technically a spoiler, but also it's really pretty and I support my fellow impatient people). See it on twitter or instagram :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FIVE

+20 years from today, First Cosmic Symposium on the Restoration of Magic, Etheria

"Is this seat free?"

It takes every bit of Heliani's courage to ask the question, and most of her fortitude to keep her voice strong while she does it. The rest of that fortitude goes to keeping her stance strong, too, when the seated woman looks up at her. Which happens slowly, both lazy and accusatory, like Heliani has disturbed her from her very important business of lounging in a spindly auditorium chair with her eyes closed.

The woman is tall - really, really tall, tall enough that she barely has to tilt her head to look at Heliani, even though she's seated and Heliani is the one standing - and alien, though everyone here is alien to Heliani. She's one of the ones who look similar enough to Heliani, albeit with less ears...Siderian, then, or Etherian (they are on Etheria, after all), or - ah, *buttercups*, Heliani forgets the rest. She can tell the woman is older, at least, with lined purple skin and biceps the size of Heliani's *head* and sharply pointed ears that have even sharper looking bones or horns or *something* sticking out of their lobes.

The woman grunts.

Heliani dithers for a moment, which must be a moment too long, because the woman jerks her head sharply at the empty seat beside her. Heliani sits down, hard, and arranges her robes, and tries to reorient herself to no longer rushing. It's tough, after so much time scrambling from the transport to her shockingly opulent guest rooms (there's a *waterfall*) to the presentation hall, though thankfully the clear signposting meant everything was easy enough to find. Now settled, more or less, she lets herself finally look around the room.

It's a lot to take in. The auditorium is crowded, packed with a riot of colors and shapes and creatures, and Heliani struggles to distinguish between what's magic (*magic!)* and what's alien

biology. Behind her sits a pair of old women with long, curling tentacles entwined together, their matching lavender t-shirts emblazoned with the word *VOLUNTEER* in big black capital letters; an amorphous jelly-like blob oozes its way through the aisle with a name tag sunk just under its surface; a set of bug-like, yellow-and-black aliens hover in front of her, the chairs there replaced with a series of perches. At the front of the room, there's a raised dais where a blue-haired woman uses nothing more than a gesture to fill five glasses of water - one at the podium, the other four along a long table with four empty chairs. At the back of the room, a large group of dark-skinned, presumably-Etherian men enter, cheerfully greeting a woman in blue and white who keeps adding decorative icicles to the walls with a wave of her hand; while they chat, a middle-aged woman in black saunters in the door and muscles her way through the group, the room's natural light glinting off the rainbow scales of her head. She catches Heliani's stare and raises an eyebrow*,* and Heliani - realizing with a start that she's being *rude* - blushes hard and turns quickly to look at the program in her lap.

Not wanting to look up again - and wondering *when this thing is going to start* because there's only so much she can do without making a fool out of herself, here with no one she knows and no one to talk to - Heliani flips the event program open to a random page. Words stare up at her, and she stares back more as an excuse to look busy than to actually read them, because she's feeling *really awkward* and looking busy...helps. A little. She's giving undue scrutiny to the pictures of a mustached man and another with a big, bulbous head, thinking that this may have been a mistake, coming here, when—

"Wouldn't, if I were you."

Heliani starts at the sound, giving a short - but mortifying - screech. When she looks up, there's an amused expression on the face of the woman sitting beside her, the one with the muscles and the sharp things in her ears, and she's got a brow quirked in a way that's condescending and also intimidating and Heliani *is* intimidated but also *annoyed*, because, "What?"

She cringes internally at the snap of her own voice, but the woman takes it in stride. “That one,” she says, nodding patronizingly at the open program in Heliani’s lap, “would be a bit much for a newcomer.”

Heliani can’t stop herself from glancing down - *Weigh Anchor and Light It Up! Lessons in Control with Lumin and Sea Hawk,* the program says - but it’s only a glance, and a second later she’s bristling, straightening up in her seat. “What makes you think I’m new?” she asks, as haughtily as she can.

The woman snorts, rolling her eyes, “Oh, kid, give it up. You couldn’t be greener if you tried.”

“I’ll have you know that I—“

“Hey, hey, calm down. Not sayin’ it’s a bad thing, you’ve just got the whole wide-eyed thing going down.”

She doesn’t say any more than that. Which is, Heliani decides, *annoying*. Possibly *rude*, too.

Heliani tries to go back to the program, but it’s even harder to concentrate on, now that she knows the presence beside her is *judging*. Not that she *look*s like she’s judging - from the corner of Heliani’s eye, the woman doesn’t seem like she’s paying attention to Heliani at all, instead once more lazing in her rickety, institutional chair with her hands locked casually behind her head and her legs straight out in front of her, crossed at the ankle. She doesn’t seem to be looking anywhere in particular, but the way she still radiates amusement makes Heliani think maybe she’s been caught staring again. Or maybe people here are just like that - Heliani doesn’t know.

Heliani doesn’t know much of anything, really. And pride isn’t getting her anywhere - isn’t that what she keeps saying, to the people at home? Isn’t that why she’s *here?* - and so she swallows hers, and screws up her courage, and ever so tentatively opens her mouth.

“So, uh,” she starts. Stalls out, then forces herself to continue with, “...which ones would be good for, um, for a newcomer?” She chews her lip for a second, and then adds quickly, “You know, if you don’t mind.”

A smile stretches across the woman’s face, broad and still condescending but also encouraging, as though she’s somehow proud of Heliani for asking. She doesn’t move from her comfortable sprawl, but does jut her chin at the program, saying, “Look for the one run by Perfuma. She’s nice, probably’ll do one of those things at the beginning where everyone says their name and their favorite flower or something. Stupid, but you’ll meet some people.”

“Thanks,” Heliani says softly, looking down. She twists the program a little in her hands, and when she looks up she finds the woman waiting patiently, attention idling around the room but still primarily on Heliani. So Heliani volunteers, “It’s my planet, you see. We’re...we don’t have magic, so I’m here to...it’s...I came to talk to She-Ra.” She tips her head up with a confidence she does not feel, takes a deep breath, dares this stranger to tell her that her tiny planet isn’t important enough for an audience with the most magical person in the universe. “I came to see what magic could mean, for us. I’m Heliani. Well, Princess Heliani, actually. Well, to be *totally* accurate, it’s Third Ancillary Princess Heliani of the—”

“Huntara,” The woman grunts, cutting her off. In the following silence - not a full silence; the hall is loud and busy, but a localized, little silence - Heliani wonders at *Huntara*. She looks incongruous there: a quiet, solid place in a mass of chattering, moving people, though she doesn’t seem uncomfortable with that fact.

“Are you…?” Heliani struggles with how to ask her question, or really what what her question even is. She’s starting to think it was maybe a rude one, and to regret opening her mouth at all.

But Huntara must guess at Heliani's thoughts, because she grunts again, a little. "Not my scene, exactly," she says, "but this is historic and all, and I've got some friends I couldn't disappoint. I'm not about to go turning down a personal invite from the lady herself, no matter if I do know how dumb she looks lickin' sand."

"Licking sa—?" Heliani starts, but she's interrupted by a series of reverberating pops, the tap-tap-tap of finger-on-microphone filling the room.

No, wait, not a finger. Are those *pincers?*

"Hello? Hello? Is this thing o—ah!" The woman shouts and the room covers their various forms of ears, everyone cringing as a loud, shrill feedback tone zings through the air. It's particularly rough on Heliani, who essentially covers her whole head. "Oh, oh gosh, this did *not* happen at sound check, I am so, so sorry, oh no, I can stop this, yes siree I can, oh—"

"Dad, I'm off magic duty. Can you...?" Heliani looks to the new voice, and realizes that sometime in her distraction the four empty seats on the dais have been filled. Or mostly filled, at least - one still stands empty, but the others are now occupied by two women and a man, all middle aged. The call was from the pink-haired woman, her eyes as well as the blonde's and the man's fixed on someone Heliani can't see, since the front row is obscured for her by the heads of other spectators. A moment later, a ball of glowing blue light sits in front of the woman with pincers, the microphone nowhere in sight. The shrill sound, thankfully, stops.

The woman with the pincers looks surprised, but not concerned. "Oh, oh that works too." Her voice carries smoothly over the crowd, magnified. Heliani gapes, as overwhelmed by her first good look at *definitely magic* as she is by everything else. At the podium, the woman continues, "Uh, thank you, Mic— ah, oh, I mean, your majesty! Uh, former majesty, is what I should say. Is there a special word for that? Like, what about— oh, right, right, sorry, uh, yeah, getting started, right."

It’s stumbling and messy, and Heliani should consider the whole display unprofessional, but the tall woman on stage is so pleasantly earnest that she can’t be anything but charmed. Even moreso when the woman clears her throat, smiles sunnily, and says in her magically-amplified voice, “Welcome! To the First Intergalactic Symposium on the Restoration of Magic.” She has to pause for a lengthy, booming round of applause, which she even joins in herself. Heliani claps; Huntara slaps her thigh a few times, lazily. Eventually the room calms, and the speaker adds, “I’m Princess Scorpia, one of your event co-chairs, and I get to get us started! We hope you all had okay trips, and…”

The talk continues, but Heliani quickly finds that despite so much that’s new and strange here, introductory speeches are just about the same all over. She barely listens to the enthusiastic prattle about session structure and accommodations and here’s-a-prize-for-the-folks-who-travelled-the-furthest, finding herself instead drawn to the trio on the stage. The woman in the middle is the hardest to keep her eyes from: the shortest, though far from the slightest, with pink-and-lavender hair piled atop her head in an elaborate, glittering updo above an equally glittering gold tiara. She sits straight-backed but not rigid, in a way that Heliani recognizes in herself - the posture of someone who’s been taught to sit-up-straight so long it’s second nature.

Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, then, Heliani thinks, but unlike Heliani’s Queen Mother, this woman can’t seem to sit still. She’s rolling her glass of water between her palms, and the water inside it jumps and sloshes with the movement. There’s a bit of added sparkle to it, too, in the place between the queen’s hands, that Heliani doesn’t think is a trick of the light.

“...our many clearly labeled signs between sessions! We’ll be in the courtyard, where you can also find water, coffee, tea, a whoo*oole* lot of tiny snacks, mints...”

As Heliani watches, the man sitting next to the queen - King Bow, Heliani’s pre-conference research suggests, bearded and broad-shouldered in a gold-trimmed jacket cut to expose his midriff -

reaches out to place a single hand on his wife's. Heliani focuses all five of her ears on the interaction, but it appears to be a mostly silent one - a single hand, and the queen lets the cup go with a *thunk* that likely only Heliani hears. Queen Glimmer doesn't turn to look at her husband, eyes politely on Princess Scorpia, but she does lean towards him bodily in a way that Heliani can't imagine is conscious. As soon as the water in the woman's glass has stopped moving, the King Bow picks it up, taking a slow, measured sip.

"...kittens, seven kinds of muffins from a lot of your planets - thank you, by the way! We're *really excited* about that! - Plumerian kazoos in the shape of Bright Moon Castle (that's the surprise giveaway) (*Oh no,* I was *not* supposed to say that)..."

The third occupant of the main table - the one between the queen and the empty chair - has the same uprightness of the woman she sits beside, but none of the irreverence. She's blonde, with hair styled into a bit of a poof at the front of her head and blue-grey eyes, sitting straight up with those eyes fixed politely at the speaker, hands clasped in her lap. She'd look calm, even, if not for the way her eyes flick - once, then again, then again - to the empty chair beside her, then the hall's main doors.

She-Ra. That's who this one is. She-Ra, Princess of Power.

"...spelunking equipment, if that's what you're into! Plus, I'll be there, and I'm a great hugger - if you want a hug, that is. Which you don't have to! But if you do, I'm your gal. So if you have any..."

Heliani can't stop herself from trying to find the magic in She-Ra. The woman's expression is set, serious and attentive; the lines of her gold-and-white suit pressed and pristine. The colors are bright, but nothing special, and there are a few flyaway hairs falling out of her coif - just a couple, nothing messy, but the kind of flyaways Heliani gets, or that her mother would. It's all very...normal.

Almost like a ripple effect, Queen Glimmer leans forward. With her hand that isn't covered by King Bow's, she pokes She-Ra in the back. The blonde jolts just a little, and Heliani hadn't even realized how tense the woman was until she sees just a little of that tension slide away. She-Ra doesn't turn to look at the queen beside her, just like Queen Glimmer hadn't turned to her husband, but the blonde woman leans ever-so-slightly towards the prod, cracks the barest hint of a smile.

It's a kind smile, rueful and genuine, paired with a bit of a head-tilt and a crinkling of the laugh-lines around her eyes. It makes Heliani want to smile, too, but that does not stop it from being entirely mundane. Heliani tries to look harder, tries to see—

"Thank you, Scorpia!" Queen Glimmer says with fervor, her voice booming magically loud across the hall. Heliani realizes she's missed not only the rest of the opening speech - Princess Scorpia isn't even on stage anymore - but the panelists' formal introductions entirely. Queen Glimmer hasn't moved from her table, leaving the podium empty, but is sitting up forward in her seat at the panelist table with the blue amplification ball dangling nonchalantly from her hand. "And thanks to everyone else here, as well. I cannot stress what an absolute joy it is to see—"

A loud sound interrupts her, carrying from the back of the hall. It's a metal-on-stone *bang*, and Heliani turns in her seat along with the other spectators. A mutter rises from the room; Heliani cranes her neck to see around her fellow audience members, many of whom who have started to stand up partially or even all the way. All of them are - like her - trying to get a glimpse of why the Bright Moon hall doors have been thrown dramatically open, admitting a gust of crisp, spring wind.

Also, apparently, a woman.

She isn't tall, but it takes Heliani a moment to realize that. The illusion of height is twofold - for one, she strides into the room like she owns it, sauntering down the central aisle without concern for the ruckus her entrance has caused. She's a study in red and

black, all sharp lines and sharp claws and sharp eyes, though those come in yellow and turquoise, and her color-matching is further broken by a gold, wing-shaped pin that glitters on her jacket lapel. Her arms remain spread wide from where they'd pushed open the door as if to present herself, and it all makes her seem like the biggest person in the room. The second reason is because of her hair, which - in contrast to the neat press of her suit - is positively huge, a spiky, voluminous mass, dark but scattered with shots of silver. It puffs around a pair of large, triangular ears and cascades down her back like an act of defiance against the careful decorum of the event, making her appear half-again as tall as she actually is.

She's also barefoot. Her footsteps fall silently as she makes her way down the central aisle, a contradictory subtlety in the midst of what might be the most unsubtle entrance Heliani has ever seen.

"Ugh," Huntara grunts, lounging lower in her chair. She's one of the few people who hasn't turned around - as far as Heliani can tell, she hasn't even bothered to move, outside her present slouch. At Heliani's questioning glance, she rolls her eyes, rumbling, "It's the fluffy one, isn't it?"

Heliani doesn't know how to respond to that, so it's good she doesn't have to. Because a moment later, the newcomer is speaking.

"What?" She drawls in a voice that isn't a shout, not at all, but which carries through the hall nonetheless. It's a commander's voice, starting from the diaphragm and ending with the full expectation that it will be heeded. Heliani has heard army generals and her mother the Queen talk like that, but she's never heard it this irreverent and casual. It's clearly meant as theater for everyone, though the words are directed at the stage, and the woman is smirking when she adds, "Thought I'd show up late? Let you do all the hard parts?"

“That’d be a bit low,” the reply is an amused one, pitched to carry just as well, “even for you.”

Heliani’s turns to see who said it, and finds the blonde woman on stage laughing. She looks...different. Heliani blinks a little, trying to make sense of what she sees. Because she’s *not* different, hasn’t changed at all, but nonetheless she’s - the only word Heliani has for it is *transformed*. Not the way Heliani’s heard she does, not with light and rainbows and flowing gold magic...except the way she looks now, how her whole body’s now relaxed confidently into her chair and her eyebrow is arched and her smile sits wide on her face, the way her chin tilts up cockily and her blue eyes flash, it feels like a prelude to all those things. She looks - not younger, because she doesn’t, she looks every inch of her experience and years, maybe even moreso, now. But - brighter.

Ah, Heliani thinks. She-Ra.

The new woman bounds - and Heliani didn’t know there was such a thing as a dignified bound, but apparently there is - her way to the dais, even as the ambient conversation of the audience gets louder, now that the presentation has effectively stalled out. Heliani turns and watches the stage, trying and failing to remember who the fourth speaker was - She-Ra and Etheria’s royalty she’d taken note of; she’s not sure she’d researched further than that. She wishes she had.

She tries to listen in to the conversation on the dais, hoping for a clue, but even her ears can’t make out what’s said over the chatter of the crowd - she can see, though, that some kind of words accompany Queen Glimmer’s stuck-out tongue, and that King Bow is laughing. She watches as the new woman waves them off, stepping over to where She-Ra tips her head up to say something else. The newcomer presses a clawed finger gently onto the center of She-Ra’s forehead and says something back, a soft grin crossing her face.

The moment passes quickly, and the newcomer does not take the empty seat but crosses to the podium instead, waving at someone

in the front row as she does. She says something - not pitched to the whole room, but louder than her conversations onstage, so Heliani hears, "No, Scorpia, stay there, you're doing enough - it's my fault anyway..." The woman looks around the podium for a moment, clearly confused, then turns when the blue amplification orb bounces off her head, tossed by a smirking Queen Glimmer. When she grabs it and speaks into it, her voice is raspy and retains that edge of command as she booms, "Hey, sorry, kitten emergency, if you can imagine. Don't worry, I'm fine. So are they. Unfortunately."

The room begins to quiet just in time to make King Bow's affronted noise audible.

The new woman gives a high laugh. "Fine, not unfortunately. We're glad the kittens are okay. Is that nice enough for you? Are you happy now?" Her voice is wry, but well received - King Bow gives a thumbs up, and a smattering of chuckles echo through the room. "*Anyway*," she continues, "I understand I missed intros, so I'll do mine real fast. Catra, Chief Royal Counselor of Bright Moon and the Etherian Princess Alliance, Co-founder of the Universal Magic Restoration Project, Co-chair of this here First Cosmic Symposium on the Restoration of Magic—"

She has to pause here for the same loud, raucous applause that had greeted the earlier mention of the symposium's title. Unlike the previous time, when the speaker joined in on the cheering, Chief Counselor Catra simply *basks* in it. Before it has a chance to die down, she raises claw-tipped hands a few times, palms up, a clear challenge to get louder - and the room obeys, Heliani carried away and cheering with it, along with added whooping sounds from behind her and a bizarre alien buzzing noise from in front of her and a full-voiced shout of *"GO WILDCAT!"* from somewhere in the front row.

Counselor Catra is laughing by the time the room really does quiet, and so is everyone else. She picks up her list as if she'd never left off. "—and current Acting Secretary of the Interplanetary Reconstruction Relief Network. I'd actually really

like to kick that last one, so if you're interested and you're competent, drop me a line at the reception, will you?" She smiles in a way that shows off too many pointed teeth to be entirely genial, leaving it to Heliani's - and the rest of the audience's - imagination what might happen to anyone who dares approach her without full confidence that they are, in fact, what she would consider competent.

There's another, less intense round of clapping, which sees her sauntering back to the table and dropping cheerfully into the seat next to She-Ra. Heliani notices that Counselor Catra leans inwards, too, just like the other three do, like planets curving unwittingly into each other's orbit.

Queen Glimmer takes the blue orb, clears her throat into it. "As I was saying, before *someone* decided to go all high drama—" Heliani chuckles with the rest of the room, notices even Huntara is smiling, just a little. It's contagious. Onstage, Chief Counselor Catra uses She-Ra's glass of water to toast first Queen Glimmer and then the audience, then takes a leisurely gulp. Queen Glimmer rolls her eyes in a way that is both affectionate and full-bodied, then smiles at the audience, "—I cannot stress what an absolute joy it is to see you all here, old friends and new. For many of you, this is not your first time hearing from me, and maybe not your first time on Etheria, either. But it's the first time we've had this many people from this many worlds, all in the same room at the same time. For those of you who are used to this kind of thing, we hope you can find an even grander place to share your experiences, to be heard and to hear from each other. For those of you who are new: welcome! We can't wait to learn from you, too, and we hope we can help in return..."

—

If the opening ceremony was overwhelming, the reception is worse.

"Huntara!" The blond woman - *She-Ra* - says, juggling her plate of finger food to wave Heliani's companion over, "You came!"

Heliani scrambles along behind Huntara, making use of her new acquaintance's presence - physical and otherwise - as it cuts a path in the crowd. Heliani spends the few moments she has before reaching the four most famous people in the room (what is her *life)* mentally revising her *here's-why-my-planet-needs-She-Ra* speech, this time with She-Ra herself as the intended audience. She also takes half a second to revel in a connection well-made, because clearly this Huntara is a good person to know.

Then they get closer.

"Loser," Chief Counselor Catra calls.

"Fluffy." Huntara responds, just as dry.

Heliani stops congratulating herself.

"She does have the Waste now, Catra, you know that," Queen Glimmer says, glancing between them. She has a twist to her lips that puts Heliani a bit more at ease, because she's clearly trying not to laugh, and she's unconcerned enough to busy herself by taking a dumpling off She-Ra's plate. She-Ra pulls the plate away with an affronted look, then pointedly takes a miniature cake for herself.

The Chief Counselor and Huntara eye each other with what seems to be a half-hearted kind of rancor, until the former plucks the cake directly from She-Ra's fingers - ignoring She-Ra's protest - and uses it to gesticulate nonchalantly, proclaiming an airy, "Only because I'm busy." Huntara snorts her skepticism in response, and the Chief Counselor ignores it, asking, "Pick up another stray?"

Heliani feels herself flush, and then Huntara rejoins with, "Worse, a princess," and Heliani flushes harder.

King Bow rolls his eyes. “Ignore them,” he says, smiling in a way so genuine that she even obeys, “It’s good to meet you, Princess…?”

“Heliani, of Spheria,” Heliani says, then adds in a rush before her nerve leaves her, “We’re small, so you wouldn’t have heard of us, but we’ve - well, of course we’ve heard of you, *everyone’s* heard of you. And Horde Prime destroyed most all our ancient records, and we know the First Ones did *something*, so we can’t know if we have magic, and, and I was here to ask, that is, I know you—“ as she loses momentum, Heliani’s mind floods with all the pleasantries she’s just skipped, all the rules of *having conversations with people* that she seems to have suddenly forgotten, not to mention the fact that all five of these *very famous and powerful people* - well, four very famous and powerful people and Huntara, who still kind of scares her - are looking at her in various states of patience and amusement. Mortified, she drops into a deep bow, forcing herself to slow down. “I’m getting ahead of myself,” she says, “I am *so sorry*, it’s...it’s an honor to meet you, Your Majesties, Counselor,” and oh sunshine and buttercups, what the *fuck* was She-Ra’s title, she know this, why does her head suddenly feel so *empty*. Princess of Power? Yes. “Princess She-Ra.”

For a moment, the whole group is silent. Heliani looks up tentatively, wondering how she is possibly going to salvage her awkwardness.

Then, Chief Counselor Catra starts to choke.

Heliani starts towards her, concerned, but when the Chief Counselor manages to clear her throat - thumping on her chest a few times to do it - it’s only to break into immediate *howls* of laughter. It’s a raucous, squeaking sound, and Heliani feels herself flushing *yet again* - she might as well make it permanent, at this point - as a few attendees in surrounding conversational clusters glance their way.

Worse, She-Ra herself is grimacing a little, though she seems more rueful than angry when she says, "Adora is fine, really."

Heliani tries to imagine calling the most magical person in the universe plain old *Adora*. This must show on her face, because She-Ra adds, "No, really, please." She glares at the Chief Counselor, who is still doubled over with cackles, "I really do prefer— can you *stop?*"

The last three words are clearly directed at the counselor, who responds by giggling even harder and all but draping herself over Pri— *Adora's* arm, jostling the plate of food she's holding. "I don't - ha! - I dunno, *Princess She-Ra,"* another round of laughter and snorts, "is that a *royal order?*"

Adora - Princess Adora? but no, *princess* seems to be the problem word here - blushes red and, transferring the plate to her other hand, shakes her arm weakly. It fails entirely to dislodge the other woman, but does spur Queen Glimmer to give the Chief Counselor a bit of a kick. "Catra," King Bow hisses as she does, "Catra, stop it, you're making our guest uncomfortable."

Heliani never finds out if King Bow's admonishment would have worked, because they're interrupted by the sound of a throat clearing. Heliani's grateful for the shift in focus, and turns to see an Etherian - older than her by about a decade; heavyset and sharp-eyed with a wide mushroom for a head - standing on the edge of the group and making wide-fingered bursting motions with their long, gill-textured hands.

"Well I'm stumped," Chief Counselor Catra says through the last of her giggles, ostentatiously wiping away a tear. She turns to the newcomer, "Communicate, Mycel. It's what I pay you for."

Queen Glimmer shoots her a sideways look. "*I* thought you paid them to do your dirty work," she says.

The mushroom person - Mycel, apparently - smiles blandly and cuts in with, "You're right, and today her dirty work is getting you

lot to talk to *other people.*"

"They're right. That *is* dirty," King Bow says, taking a muffin from Adora's plate.

"Scatter." Mycel says, bursting their hand again, "You are at your own *cosmic-level* conference. You don't get to spend the reception hanging out with each other. Talk to your guests."

"Bu—" King Bow starts, around a mouthful of muffin.

"Huntara doesn't count." Mycel says firmly, then turns to Huntara, "Hi Huntara, how are you?"

"Just fine, kid. Good to see you're not letting the assholes get to you." There's another minor glare-off between Chief Counselor Catra and Huntara, which the latter leaves off with a smirk. "Ah, and here's Princess Heliani. She's a guest."

In the short time that everyone's attention has been off her, Heliani's embarrassment has had time to abate; it dissipates the rest of the way as Mycel goes red as their mushroom cap. It's like there's only so much mortification to go around, and now they've taken the pot of it - which might be an unkind reaction to have, finding her own assurance in someone else's mistake, and that guilt makes her feel particularly sympathetic when Mycel stammers out, "Oh, oh I am *sorry*, your highness, I completely missed you. I, uh, I'm not usually so rude. Welcome to Bright Moon."

Heliani smiles and bows, significantly more graceful than her last attempt. She murmurs her own pleasantries right before Adora speaks up. "Mycel's right. If Huntara hadn't brought Princess Heliani over, we'd all still be hiding from our own party."

There's something of a note of authority in her voice, however casual, and it startles Heliani to notice it. It shouldn't - this is *She-Ra*, after all - but Heliani thinks it's because it isn't intentional. Or at least, it doesn't *seem* intentional - unlike Chief Counselor Catra's performative archness or the straightforwardness of Queen

Glimmer or even the kind firmness from King Bow, Adora's authority sits in her voice like an afterimage, like she's so used to making decisions that decision-making just sneaks in around the edges, whether she means it or no.

No one else even seems to notice. They must be, Heliani thinks, used to it.

"*Fine*," Queen Glimmer sighs, then addresses Heliani directly when she adds, "anyway, you may have a more productive conversation with...less of us."

She plucks a tiny soufflé from Adora's plate, then leaves them by *actually disappearing*, which no one but Heliani even seems to register. She's still reeling from it when King Bow makes his own escape with a charmingly extravagant bow in Heliani's direction. He grabs a cookie from Adora's plate as he goes - Adora bats at his hand to no avail - and then he uses his free hand to make a cheerfully complicated movement as he walks away. Heliani realizes it's directed at an attendee with three eyes and no mouth, and becomes engrossed for a moment in watching the gestural conversation there. She's fully engaged in trying to follow it until she hears Mycel's voice again.

"Well?"

Heliani whips around, ready with an apology, but she finds that the question - exasperated, expectant - wasn't for her. Mycel's arms are crossed and their foot is tapping, eyes fixed on Chief Counselor Catra. She, in turn, widens her own eyes, sharp mouth paused comically around a mini tart. She points to herself with theatrical shock.

Mycel just cocks a brow. "Yes, you. Scatter."

The Counselor sniffs. "You can't tell me what to do," she says petulantly. "I'm your boss."

Mycel shrugs, and though Heliani can't hear the words *can't argue with that,* she can see it all over their face. They cast Heliani an

apologetic look, and she does her best to send a sympathetic one back. Meanwhile, Chief Counselor Catra starts perusing Adora's plate again, only to realize - as Heliani realizes it too - that it's now empty. Adora tries to smile innocently, but the effect is ruined by her puffed full cheeks.

An emphatically silent, thoroughly undignified argument of facial expressions erupts between Adora and Counselor Catra, which Mycel interrupts sweetly, "Excuse me, Adora, you see, my boss is __"

"I'm going, I'm going!" Chief Counselor Catra announces. Mycel is clearly aiming for innocence and Adora is smirking as much as she can while chewing, and Catra throws her hands up in surrender. "*Before* you two gang up on me."

She nods to Heliani, slides her tail across Adora's hip-to-arm-to-wrist, and shoulder-checks Mycel as she passes them. Mycel leans into it, knocking her back just as hard, and Heliani catches them flashing each other matching grins before Mycel's face schools itself back into pleasant politeness, and they leave too.

And then with a jolt, Heliani realizes she's alone, insofar as it's possible to be in a crowd, with *She-Ra, Princess of Power* and—

Huntara is nowhere in sight. Heliani looks around, perplexed and a little frantic, then back to Adora at the sound of her chuckle.

"She does that," Adora says. "Take it as a compliment; she wouldn't leave unless she thought you'd be okay."

"Really?" Heliani asks, unsure.

Adora laughs out loud this time, smiling broadly. "Really. But don't tell her I told you - she'll think you're calling her soft." She smiles at Heliani, "So, your maybe-magic planet, yeah? We can send a Survey & Research Team down with a Magic-o-Meter for that. Also for the records thing, though I'm pretty sure our historians are all booked - do you have cool buildings? We can probably bribe Teau into a stint if you do. Oh, are you speaking for everyone on-

planet, or just a group? Because we usually like to have reps from everywhere when we send down a Briefing Team, and that should come first, though we *will* carry over members between groups, so you'll always have a familiar face. There's an intake form for all that, actually, I should—" She stops, and Heliani is both mortified and grateful knowing what she must see to make her smile go gentle, her voice slower, "Now *I'm* getting ahead of *my* self. Hey. What do you say we take a walk?" She nods to a door that opens onto the glittering Bright Moon Castle grounds.

Heliani blinks in overwhelm - just an ongoing state, at this point, really - and surprise. "What?" She asks nonsensically, then gathers herself at Adora's patient glance. She spares a longing thought for the peaceful-looking, much less panic-inducing garden, as well as her botched plea for her planet, but out of a sense of politeness makes herself say, "I can...handle it. And I'm sure you can't be away, you must have guests you have to—"

Adora cuts her off with a wave of her hand and a firm voice, "You *are* my guest, Princess Heliani. I'm here to talk to the representatives of planets involved and interested in magic - surely you are exactly that. I'm stepping out - be back in a bit."

Her last sentence is nearly a non-sequitur, said with just the same even, cheerful tone as the rest of her statement, but directed more towards the air over Heliani's shoulder than to her face. Heliani turns to see no one in particular there, and then - following Adora's gaze - Chief Counselor Catra, halfway across the room. She's gesturing at a spindly, gray-skinned conversant whose big eyes are set in an even bigger head, and - now that Heliani's looking - she sees the large, triangular ear closest to them twitch. Heliani's ears twitch in sympathy, a little. Chief Counselor Catra turns casually to take a drink off a passing tray, and when she does she looks directly at Heliani.

She winks.

When Heliani looks back to Adora, she finds her still gazing fondly across the room in that direction. It's a long moment, longer

maybe than it should be, and Heliani feels almost like she's interrupting when she asks, "Are you sure? You won't be needed?"

Adora glances at her, then back to the room. Heliani follows her gaze from Chief Counselor Catra in her conversation to King Bow in another one and Queen Glimmer in yet a third, and then to sweep over the rest of the space. It's a technicolor burst of countless planets' worth of peoples, a cacophony of joyous laughter and serious intensity and thoughtful curiosity, scattered with a veritable legion of lavender-shirted volunteers and an undercurrent of random, offhand bursts of spontaneous magic. It's still overwhelming, but it's also engrossing and astounding and brilliant, thrumming with welcoming enthusiasm. A whole universe, or the shape of one, waiting for Heliani to notice that she's already stepped inside.

"They'll be just fine," Adora says. When Heliani turns, it's to see her beaming. "Now come, and you can tell me about your planet."

Chapter End Notes

> Today's fun game: guess who the rest of the pov characters will be! You've seen all of them.
>
> Putting this at the bottom because my top a/n became a monster, even though this is always top of my heart: a huge thank you to the folks who read this stuff over for me. EXTRA HUGE thanks to the folks who listened to me bitch incessantly while writing it and even more incessantly while editing - you know who you are, and I know how you feel, because dear god am I sick of hearing myself dither at this point. I promise it's probably over now that I've started posting the thing.

FOUR: +14 years, Third Galactic Supercluster Annual Forum, Liena

Chapter Summary

Glimmer attempts both presentation & mediation.

Chapter Notes

I did not mean to take so long to update, but I got in a fight with the pacing of this chapter and apparently the only solution was to put the thing away for a while, write something else, and come back to it ready to edit ruthlessly. And, indeed, ruthlessly it has been edited. So: if you enjoyed last chapter, where very little happened, I hope you also enjoy this one, where *lots of things* happen.

As a reminder on the timeline, this fic is going backwards in time, so this chapter occurs about six years before chapter 1.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FOUR

+14 years, Third Galactic Supercluster Annual Forum, Liena

On planet Liena, the sky is falling. It comes down in orange and turquoise, waves and orbs and warbling masses of bright light dropped from above one by two by ten, lighting up the craggy, forested landscape with an eerie, uncomfortable glow. The space above Liena's surface, just this morning pink-and-cream calm, is now blocked by a series of enormous grey ovals: hulking, hovering metal contraptions that obscure the day's natural light. They replace it with their own metallic bulk as well as the balls of light that they hurl forth, all vivid, saturated hues that seem to mock the gentle pleasantness Liena's atmosphere is known for.

"...and as you can see from this slide, learning to use your new magic is not always going to be easy. In fact, it can be really, really, *really* hard. You start at the top…"

The sky is falling on Liena, and Queen Glimmer of Etheria drones on as if it isn't. Though *drone* is the wrong word, really. Lumin is pretty sure Queen Glimmer is incapable of droning - her voice is high and lilting and a little grating, with variable ups and downs that make it impossible for Lumin to entirely tune her out. She is...animated, for lack of a better word, energetic in the sharp peaks and shallow valleys of her voice as well as in the waving of her arms.

But Lumin isn't watching her. From inside the safety of the thirteenth floor of Liena's primary convention hall, Lumin watches out the window as each successive volley of light either succeeds or - mercifully - fails to land. The failures are more common, as the alien warrior She-Ra and her two companions, King Bow and Chief Counselor Catra, dart from cliff to treetop to balcony to intercept the missile-like balls of light, redirecting them towards their blue-and-red spiky cat-alien, which seems able to absorb the things without harm.

"...metaphor of a slide because once you get started, it can be really hard to stop, and it's not always something you feel like you can control. There's a lot more magic around these days, as planets sign on to the Restoration Project, and…"

The problem is when the light-orbs make it through She-Ra and her team's defenses. Their effect on the places they succeed in hitting sets Lumin's teeth on edge, his spine tensing and his fingers going black-knuckled on the edge of the desk where he's seated. The attack outside is not destructive, and yet it is, as each hit to any living thing *changes* it into another. The grass one blue lightball slammed into had become a flock of ostriches, at the start, and that hadn't been bad, but then a duck in the lake had been turned into an elephant and begun to drown, and it'd stopped being funny pretty fast after that.

She-Ra had saved the newly-made elephant, lifting the creature out of the lake one-handed, but not before Lumin had gasped in horror and a lamp had burst, here in the conference room. Now, another ball of light hurtles towards a pair of picnickers running for cover, and Lumin feels his own gut try to throttle him as it gets closer...closer...closer—

"...can teleport everywhe—"

Another lamp explodes.

"—*fuck!"*

The training session attendees scream, ducking for cover as the shards of its shattered casing rain down. Queen Glimmer interrupts her own talk to throw out a hand towards the commotion, raising a pink forcefield for the glass to plink against harmlessly. It's a flimsy thing, the barrier she makes, saving everyone from the worst of the sharpness but still coming apart even before the glass is finished falling. Queen Glimmer flexes her hand, looking frustrated.

"Is everyone okay over there?" She asks impatiently. "Yes? *Good.* Look, I don't want to do this *either* right now, okay? But you all have *very volatile* and *very new* magic, and this was *very hard* to schedule. And it's *important!*" She stamps her foot, hands on her hips as she insists, "She-Ra has it handled, trust me! We - ugh - *they* are *very good at this*! Now if you would *pay attention!* No, not out there, don't look out there, look *at me!"*

Lumin tries, he really does. But he can't stop from checking out the window, where She-Ra is shepherding the picnickers into the relative safety of a nearby cave. They're unscathed, he sees, and Lumin breathes a sigh of relief, forcing away imaginings of being squashed as a bug or felled as a tree.

The civilians stashed away, She-Ra vaults up to the top of the cliff to scan the sky, where she stands a tall, intense line of muscle and determination, resplendent in red and gold and white. Her

shining hair ripples in the wind, shimmering even brighter gold in the sky's blaze, her sword flashes where she holds it aloft, and the hostile lights are reflected in her brilliant blue eyes, which glare with steady, superhuman focus at their oncoming beams. To one side of her, King Bow stands - less tall, but nearly as imposing - his midriff bare and only one eye focused, the other closed to aim with casual, practiced nonchalance. He holds an arrow nocked and ready, a sparkle where the uncanny glow of Liena's current sky catches its tip. To She-Ra's other side crouches Chief Counselor Catra, balanced on the balls of her feet and the claw-tipped fingers of one hand, ears pressed back and mouth a snarl, all at once dynamic and frozen as she prepares to spring.

BANG

"ADORA!" Queen Glimmer booms shrilly through the slammed-open window. "What the *fuck* are you doing?!"

She-Ra's posture goes slightly less determined, her face slightly more confused. "Uh, I'm…" The acoustics of the cliffside carry her voice even as she first gestures awkwardly with her sword, then uses it to backhand a ball of malicious light that careens her way. Danger averted, she goes back to vague gesticulations to the scene around her.

Queen Glimmer gives something between a huff and a scream. "*Better question,"* she shouts, "*do you know* what *I* am doing?!"

Another ball of light veers into the team's path. This one is averted first by King Bow's arrow, which bursts into some kind of opaque sack around it, and then by Chief Counselor Catra, who uses She-Ra's still-outstretched sword as a springboard into a leap, catching the safely covered lightball and dragging it off course. Their spiky feline companion jumps up to meet the Chief Counselor halfway, popping the bag with their teeth and absorbing its contents harmlessly.

She-Ra uses a ribbon of rainbow magic to catch Chief Counselor Catra by the waist midair and yank her back to the clifftop. She

catches the other woman one-armed, then shifts nervously. "You're uh. You're giving a presentation?"

"I *am*!" Queen Glimmer shouts. "And *do you know* how I *feel* about *giving presentations?!"* Her shout loses what minimal civility it had on the last two words, practically snarling them.

She-Ra bats away another lightball, though she does it while looking somewhat cowed. She starts to answer, "You don't like giving—" at the same time that King Bow calls a helpful, "She doesn't like giving—"

"*I don't like giving presentations!"* Queen Glimmer cuts them both off. "They *suck! First* there are the *hours* it takes to put these fuckers *together*—"

"It's the same presentation she always does, she doesn't even prep anymore—" Chief Counselor Catra's mutter cuts in.

"—*and then* I have to stand for *ages* in this *fucking boring* room with these *fucking bored* attendees—"

"—plus 'Cel and I wrote half of it anyway—"

"—who *aren't even listening,* even though they're going to *ask me questions*—"

"—the rest is true, though, it's really boring."

"—about the *exact things I said* because they *do want to know this* but no one can *manage* to *listen the first time!"*

She-Ra looks perplexed. She turns to the Chief Counselor. "I thought you said you made it more interesting." Another lightball veers towards them; She-Ra seems too engrossed in the conversation to notice, so Chief Counselor Catra easily tugs the sword out of She-Ra's hands to avert it herself. "Ooh, nice one!" She-Ra adds, watching the lightball sail away.

At the window, Queen Glimmer's glower gets even stormier. On the bluff, tougher to see but still discernible, Counselor Catra's expression matches it. "Apparently," the Counselor says, disdain dripping from the words as now *she* uses the sword to gesticulate, "*practical demonstrations* are prohibited at the Annual Forum."

"This seems pretty practical to me!" King Bow notes, deflecting another lightball back into the sky, this time with an arrow that has a mirror on its tip.

"Just...*deal with it*, okay!?" Queen Glimmer shouts, then slams the window shut. Lumin thinks he may detect a hint of longing in the way her gaze lingers on the conflict outside, and for a moment he wonders if she's about to leave them to their own devices in order to join the fray. She doesn't, and instead she yanks the blinds down, obscuring the scene outside.

The blinds - and the window - stay closed for only a few tense minutes. Queen Glimmer is in the midst of an impassioned rant about *yes, okay, fine, we'll reschedule* when a series of bright, eerie yellow lights filter through the blinds. A moment later, the tentacles appear.

Lumin screams.

Three more lamps burst in the room as he scrambles up, backing away in horror as he sees two more long, thin, *writhing* shadows join the first one, the one which just *slapped* itself on the window beside him. The shapes curl and twist behind the blinds as the *thing* outside drags itself along the building's surface.

"What?" Queen Glimmer's annoyed voice breaks through, and Lumin has just enough presence of mind to point. She doesn't hesitate at the sight, just stomps over and grumpily pulls up the blinds, yanking open the window to reveal…

...an octopus?

It's...pretty much just an octopus. Light from the bombardment outside floods the room to illuminate an arrow with a suction-cup

tip stuck on the window's surface, the octopus curled around it. Its tentacles tangle there against the glass and cling for dear life, and a bow and quiver designed for a much larger creature dangle from a pair of its hanging limbs.

"Glimmer!" the octopus says.

And: "Bow!?" Queen Glimmer replies.

What follows is a mad scramble, as the octopus' voice - how is it talking?! Lumin abandons that question immediately as *too much to handle* - goes rough and dry and choked. While they can't find a bucket, someone does think to dump out the large bin of forms that say *How'd we do? Let us know your suggestions for the event!,* and someone else gets just enough control of their water magic to fill it, though not without drenching most of the room in the effort.

Queen Glimmer dumps King Bow of Bright Moon and Etheria into the bin, and he sinks into the water gratefully, a look Lumin somehow identifies as disgruntled on his octopus face as he tries to arrange his tentacles to soak in the maximum liquid. Ultimately, a subset of them do end up flopped on the floor, but he no longer appears to be struggling or in pain.

Upon receiving reassurance that he is indeed as *okay* as possible under the circumstances - the circumstances being that he's an octopus now - Queen Glimmer crouches down, slicks her now-wet hair away from her face, and says with something between barely controlled impatience and fury, "What. Happened."

"I'm a...actually I don't think we have these on Etheria," he examines the suction cups on one tentacle, before someone meekly offers the word *octopus*. This seems to both distress and excite him, and he puts those tentacles to his head. "Octopus! I'm an octopus! I have *so many arms* - actually that part's pretty cool, though I obviously can't shoot like this. Except *actually,* with some practice, I guess I could—"

“Bow!” The octopus who is King Bow stops talking, and Queen Glimmer looks out the window to a landscape rife with balls of glowing light and, increasingly, a variety of inconvenient animal life. She rubs her forehead. “Bow. What *happened?* You were doing so *well!”*

“Yes, er,” King Bow says, “That was before everyone got abducted.”

Queen Glimmer - and the room of baffled and terrified presentation attendees - all stare at King Bow.

Then Queen Glimmer says slowly, “Everyone got...*what?!”*

“Abducted! You closed the window and then there was a single beam of yellow light and She-Ra and Catra and Melog just kind of floated—“

“Abducted by *who?!”*

“Uh…” King Bow makes a sort of confused, dismissive gesture in the air with a single tentacle, “...aliens?”

Queen Glimmer gives an exasperated shout of frustration and throws her hands up in the air, “Bow, *everyone is an alien! We* are aliens! I mean, have you made any *contact?!”*

King Bow looks as sheepish as it is possible for an octopus to look, which is apparently quite. “Oh, uh…no.”

Queen Glimmer growls, then stomps over to the window, which she opens. She manifests a glowing orb of her own, lavender light, which flickers and splutters. She glares at it, and it solidifies in her hand; when she speaks, her voice is amplified into the sky.

“HELLO.” Queen Glimmer booms. “I AM QUEEN GLIMMER OF BRIGHT MOON AND ETHERIA. YOU HAVE INTERRUPTED MY PRESENTATION, ABDUCTED MY FRIENDS, AND TURNED MY HUSBAND INTO AN OCTOPUS. I SPEAK ON BEHALF OF NO

PLANET SAVE MY OWN, THOUGH I WOULD BE *HAPPY* TO SERVE AS MEDI—"

"Glimmer!" King Bow shouts, as a skyful of orange light comes streaking towards them.

"Get down!" Queen Glimmer screams, and then for a moment there's nothing but light and sound and the whirl of Queen Glimmer's staff, a clatter of institutional furniture followed by a low, bovine *moo.* Lumin dives to the floor, stomach in his throat, an errant light careening closer and closer and no no *no noNO*—

He throws his hands up over his head. There's pressure there, hot against them, pushing and pushing and Lumin pushes back, shoves harder and harder and then—

A burst of light, sharp and shattering. A rain of glass, cascading around his shoulders without touching him at all.

And then: darkness.

Lumin breathes two, gasping breaths, in and out. He feels for a tail, or ears, or tentacles or leaves, but - no. Same bald head, wide at the forehead and narrow at the chin; two spindly gray arms and another two legs; all seven long fingers—

"So. Magic, huh?"

It's a moment before Lumin realizes Queen Glimmer is talking to him. He looks up to see her at the center of the room, her damp, brightly colored hair glittering in the darkness as she eyes the scene outside. The orange-and-blue glow of falling lights crosses her face in errant pulses, also illuminating a variety of aliens and one royal octopus and one Lienan cow, all bunched up away from the window.

But the *source* of the light - that *stays* outside, is the thing. It's a moment more before Lumin realizes why - a rose-gold sheen to the window, keeping all of it out.

“You...you did it.” He says, quietly.

“No, I didn’t,” Queen Glimmer replies, then looks at him, “I tried to, but Liena isn’t a big fan of my magic, I think. At least, not on this scale.”

“Then...then how…” Lumin’s voice falters. The forcefield flickers. He blinks at it, confused.

“Nope, nope!” Queen Glimmer rushes out, “Don’t let go! Uh...shields! Roofs! Uh...fences? No, not fences, fences have holes…”

“...What are you talking about?” Lumin asks, then adds, “Your, uh. Majesty.”

Queen Glimmer puts her hands on her hips. “Look,” she says, “I’m not really going to get anything done with all this coming down, so I need you to put that,” she gestures at the forcefield in the window, “up there.”

Lumin stares at her. And then, he asks, voice a squeak: “*Me!?”*

The answer is: yes, him. It’s like being in the educational session, again, though this time his eyes are closed and Queen Glimmer’s lilting voice is just for him. She speaks continuously, slow-going, though sometimes Lumin doesn’t think he can hear anything except the inside of his own head, or the pounding, gentle-strong-sharp-beaming of Liena’s three suns, something that isn’t quite a sound but also isn’t quite not a sound.

He gasps when he realizes that *something is happening*, because the realization comes with the feeling like he’s burning alive, simmering in his gut and out his throat and also miles and miles away up in the sky all at once. It’s Queen Glimmer’s voice - not soft, but certain - that brings him back each time, sometimes with instructions but mostly with assurances that it’s *happening*, that he’s *doing it*, that it’s *working.* It’s clumsy; the way he presses Liena's light into something substantial, thin in some places and thick in others. But then - then it’s smoother, more uniform.

Reinforced, in a way. Not with the increasingly familiar pastel-gold-hot Lienan sunlight that's inside him, but with something cooler yet sharper, with bright edges that look, in his mind's eye, like a purple-pink so vibrant it almost stings to touch.

Queen Glimmer's magic doesn't mix with his, and does not overwhelm him or direct him. It's the opposite, actually, and he watches - if *watches* is the right word, and it's not, but the right word doesn't exist so *watches* will have to do - watches the pink glow slide into the patterns his sunlight started, reinforcing it and then backing off, leaving the combined barrier in Lumin's hands. And it is indeed in Lumin's hands, for as Queen Glimmer withdraws her presence - but, somehow, not her magic, not entirely - he finds the whole of it left to him.

Queen Glimmer lets go, and Lumin holds up the sky.

"Can you open your eyes?" Her voice comes, steady as a heartbeat.

Lumin can, and Lumin does. He ignores the room of people - staring at him, he expects, though he can't focus on that now - to look out the window.

There's a rose-gold sheen to the whole sky. Balls of light pound at the barrier of it, but they break up against the strength of what's there. Lumin feels each of them in a way that does not hurt - he pushes back at every volley.

This morning, Lumin couldn't turn on a lightbulb.

"You got it?" Queen Glimmer asks.

Later, he'll have questions - about how he's doing what he's doing, and how he can do it again, and how she knew just what to say. For now, he nods.

She nods back, a sharp, brisk motion, as sharp and brisk as he knows her magic feels. Then, Queen Glimmer drags a toppled chair from the puddle in the middle of the room to the open

window. It splashes through and then scrapes loudly across the rest of the floor, then pounds the wall equally loudly as she drags it up onto the wide windowsill. She climbs up on top of its seat and conjures a lavender ball of amplification magic once more. She turns to the sky.

"*NOW.* WE ARE GOING TO TALK. LIKE *MATURE*. *FUCKING*. *ADULTS*."

Chapter End Notes

If you're wondering why the acoustics make no sense, all I have to say is these are cartoon aliens and I do what I want.

Yes I remember Octavia exists and yes I think that makes my stupid octopus joke even funnier.

Bonus points to anyone who can guess how I named the planet.

THREE: +7 years, Northern Intergalactic Planetary Coalition Summit, Floccul

Chapter Summary

Catra engages with management on multiple levels.

Chapter Notes

In May 2020, at the height of the post-s5 catradora craze, I posted a fanfic. Four days later, buried in a series of what are essentially essays, I got the following comment:
I'm sure there's some interesting adjustment from "We just saved the world thanks to a giant magical glowing sword and the power of love!" to "The major issue on the table today is the reallocation of trading tariffs based on expected restored magical yields. We've put four hours on the agenda for it, followed by lunch and break-out sessions."
To which I replied, that same day:
break-out sessions. Fuck, break-out sessions. Catra and Glimmer stuck in break-out sessions. Catra and Glimmer RUNNING break-out sessions. I hope you don't mind if I take a note on this, because it's glorious and horrible and I love it.
And anyway the draft I started the next day became this chapter, and then this fic.

So thank you thank you thank you to Urist, for all the beta-ing and for listening to me ramble, but mostly in this case for that one (two, five, etc.) time(s) you commented on Learning Curve a wholeass year ago. If anyone ever gives me shit about this fic, I'm going to lay all the blame on you.

As a reminder, we're going back in time, so this would be 7 years before the previous chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THREE

+7 years, Northern Intergalactic Planetary Coalition Summit, Floccul

"Adora, no."

"I think you mean Adora*, yes."*

"No, Adora, I definitely mean— Bow! Bow, stop her. Can he hear me? He can't hear me, can he."

It's a testament to the high quality of Bright Moon technology that Mycel can hear every single sound coming from the communicator speakers with perfect clarity - She-Ra's voice, sure, but also every shout and clang, every squawk and high pitched ringing noise. It's a testament to the strangeness of whatever is happening on the other end that Mycel can't for the life of them figure out what it *is,* other than some kind of combat (probably). Mycel could take one step to the left and crane their head to see the screen, but—

"Adora, get back here! I don't *care* how many beaks it has, we are having a *conversation!"*

—they do not, which is a testament to how downright *scary* Senior Counselor Catra is, waving the communicator around irately as she stomps her way into the conference room.

Instead, Mycel keeps their back flat to the wall and their arms tight around their tablet organizer full of notes, doing their best not to make sudden movements or *breathe* or anything else that might disturb their direct supervisor's call. Because Mycel wouldn't want to make a *bad impression*, since it's not like they've met before. Somehow. After a whole two weeks on the job.

(Not that Mycel's bitter or anything.)

(It's just, you'd think they'd have met by now, right? Like, sure, she's *Senior Counselor Catra*, and she's the top aide to Queen Glimmer, not to mention the side-work she's been doing on the

nascent Reconstruction Relief Network, plus the way her name always comes up in She-Ra's seemingly non-stop adventures. Mycel *knows* she must be busy, because Mycel knows how much she's doing, has even since before Queen Glimmer gave them the run-down at their interview and hired them on the spot. Because Mycel *does their research* before they apply to a job, and they applied to this job in particular for a reason, and the reason is that *this is what they want to do*. Live and work and help in this whole universe Etheria has never seen before, see up close each of these stars Mycel never grew up but which they know their little sister is now watching every single night in Erelandia's sky. And, to be fair, that *is* what Mycel is getting to do, already, out here on this strange planet where everything is, for lack of a better word, *floofy*, where Mycel is synthesizing the best ways to communicate how magic manifests and is going to have that work be used for something that *matters.*

But...well, it's just, you'd think that amid all that, Mycel's new boss would at least drop by to say *hi* or *welcome* or *what's your name?,* or even *tell me the progress on that project Queen Glimmer gave you,* right!?)

(Apparently not.)

Mycel's efforts at unobtrusiveness are either successful or pointless, because Catra doesn't even seem to notice them, slamming the conference room door behind her. The cat-creature that likes to follow her around shows slightly more interest, sniffing briefly at Mycel's knees, and Mycel eyes it warily before they're distracted by something *much more important*, namely what Senior Counselor Catra is doing to their *files.*

Because Mycel has the digital summary cradled in their arms, sure, but that doesn't mean it's finished, and it's still just a summary, not everything. *Everything* is in physical form, and *everything* has been meticulously organized in stacks and notecards and neat little sticky notes, all along the conference table, and - well, it's a lot. It's the last two weeks of Mycel's life, and it's not perfect, but Mycel's *proud* of it.

Catra pushes it aside like it's nothing.

Mycel's not even sure *pushes* is the right word. *Sweeps*, maybe, like all that work is a bunch of dust bunnies to be brushed away; *shoves* it to make a blank space on the table. Mycel lets out an involuntary squeak of horror, which Catra ignores entirely as she sets up the communicator on a stand in the newly cleared spot.

"Do you think the First Ones had some kind of thing for caves?" She-Ra asks conversationally. Mycel can see the screen now, so they can see her smiling face, the left side of it covered in a spray of something blue and liquid that drips from golden hairline to chin. The rocky cave wall behind her is aglow with bioluminescent moss, and somewhere offscreen there's a combined war cry and squawk, followed by a loud *boom.* "Don't get me wrong, I know there's also been a bunch of tunnels and jungles and that one cool underwater grotto thing, but a lot of these things are just in caves. I wonder if—"

"Adora." Senior Counselor Catra says flatly, sitting down in one of the conference room's much-too-fluffy chairs. She sinks into it further than she apparently expect, because she growls and flails until she's perched upright on the edge, then rubs a hand across her face. "You're changing the subject. You *cannot* do the magic-sword-cannon-thing."

There's really no other way to describe it - She-Ra *pouts.* "Why *not?"*

"It's dangerous! You need more back-up, in case it goes—"

"What do you mean, it's dangerous?! You were all for it last week!"

There's a shout of "*Adora!"* from offscreen, but She-Ra doesn't turn. She's busy smirking while Catra hisses, "That's because *then* we were planning for *me* to be there, and I—"

"Oh, I get it - you don't wanna miss it! Aww, you're *sad!"*

"I'm not!" Catra's tail is bottle-brush spiked.

"You could have just *asked me* to wait for you! Unless you're not coming out with me anymore, now that you're all *promoted*?" She-Ra's grin gets even wider, if possible, bald pride glowing so brightly on her features that Mycel finds themself practically blinking away an afterimage.

If Catra has a similar experience, it's not for long. "Ugh," she says, slumping into her seat and not seeming to care this time when she sinks into the fluff of it, "Glimmer told you about that."

"Bow mentioned it, actually. What is *up* with you, anyway? I remember a time when I was all *look I'm a Force Captain* and you couldn't decide if you were more jealous or power-mad about it." Catra must make a face, because She-Ra adds, "Oh, come on. You don't do that anymore."

Mycel's hands itch to fix their notes - still sitting crumpled to the side - but they push the feeling away, still determined not to interrupt. Not that it's clear what they'd be interrupting - Catra's grumbling so low that Mycel can't hear the words. Whatever they are, they make She-Ra's whole face go soft, then sly.

She-Ra opens her mouth, but instead of her voice there's the other one coming through the speakers, shouted from offscreen. "Adora!" This time it's louder and more urgent. "What are you *doing*?!"

"Be right there, Bow! Catra called," She-Ra says absently, still smirking through her screen at the senior counselor. Her voice goes clearly flirtatious as she adds, "You know, Catra, if it'll make you feel better, I can always *demonstrate* my *cann*—"

"What could *possibly* be *so important* that you need to deal with it *right now!?"* The offscreen voice - King Bow's, Mycel thinks - shouts. "We are in. *Active. Combat."*

She-Ra looks perplexed, like the question doesn't make sense, and says matter-of-factly, "...Catra called." In reply there's another

shout-squawk-clang, this time accompanied by a spray of iridescent orange feathers across the communicator screen and a pained look from She-Ra. "Okay, yeah, I gotta get that. CatraILoveYouMissYouSoMuchBYE."

"Adora, you—" the pad shakes around, and then shows the rocky ceiling of the cave, and then cuts to black. "Ugh." The senior counselor settles moodily back in her chair, ears pinned back and tail lashing, though with a blush on her cheeks that Mycel is fully prepared to absolutely ignore. Except they don't get a chance to, because then all at once, Catra surges up to standing and around, the blush replaced fully with ire. "What the *fuck* are you still doing here?!"

And of course she's staring at Mycel, her eyes narrowed into irritated little slits.

Mycel...should have been prepared for this.

Mycel is *not.*

"I...I, uh..."

"I, uh," Senior Counselor Catra mimics, voice high pitched and mean. She flashes her teeth in a snarl, "Answer the question."

On one hand, Mycel's mind is now a nonstop litany of every horror story they've ever heard about Senior Counselor Catra. That she yelled at a trainee last month for cutting her in line at Salineas' Dolphin Social. How she once threw King Bow off a cliff. The almost certainly exaggerated claim that she tried to single-handedly end reality, back before the war with Horde Prime.

On the other hand, Mycel's been on this project for *two weeks*, and has *every right to be here*, and can't stop looking over Catra's shoulder at their notes all crumpled on the table. It's enough to make them square their shoulders, even if they do remain pressed against the wall. They make their voice as firm as they can manage when they say, "I work here. Queen Glimmer has her presentation for the—"

“The Summit tomorrow, yeah, *obviously*. What’re you, the agenda? Get out.”

“No, I’m—” Okay, so yeah, she’s still terrifying, “I’ve been working on—”

“I don’t care.”

“—the queen’s presentation notes—”

“Well, you can fuck right off. That’s my job, everyone knows that’s my job.”

“I was assigned, since you were— You were, uh.” Mycel never thought of themself as someone who cowers, but they can feel themself shifting to try to put the large, curved, mushroom-cap part of their head between themself and Catra’s gaze. As soon as they notice they’re doing it, they force themselves to stop, jutting out their chin instead. “We thought - we thought you would be on the—“

“Fancy new planet, having a grand old time fighting a building-sized Horde-corrupted ostrich with a sword-cannon made out of magic light? *You don’t say*.”

Mycel does not, in fact, say anything at all. Mycel tries their best to blend into the wall while Senior Counselor Catra and her alien cat-creature stalk back and forth across the room at an increasingly agitated pace.

“Just like,” Catra rants, “I wasn’t *supposed* to get fucking *sick,* and I was *supposed* to be *anywhere but* this *fucking fluffy cloud-city* at this *stupid fucking event.* But I *am*— hold up. You said assigned. Who the fuck assigned you?” Mycel opens their mouth. They should know better than to expect to manage words, though, and they’re not even surprised when Catra cuts them off before they say anything with a full bodied groan of, “That *bitch*.”

Before Mycel can even process their confusion, Senior Counselor Catra is punching more buttons on her communicator. A few

seconds later, Queen Glimmer's face is on the screen.

"Catra? Can't talk long, I've been in nonstop meet—"

"You *replaced me!?"*

"What?!" Queen Glimmer looks positively appalled, and a moment later both women are all but shouting overtop of one another. "No! If you'd *listened to me*—"

"You did! When you said you had the presentation *handled,* I—"

"—instead of *flirting with Adora* over *cannon-swords, you*—"

"—didn't think you meant *pawning it off* on some newbie with—"

"—would realize that you *have an employee!"*

"I *what!?"*

"Catra." Queen Glimmer says, and it sounds annoyed and fond and exasperated all at once, "I'm not just throwing job titles at you for no reason. *Senior* counselor implies *non-senior* counselors, I thought you got that." She sighs. She holds up a finger to someone offscreen, and then there's a moment while she appears to walk into a less populated area, at which point she fixes Catra with a hard stare. "This isn't a four-person operation anymore, Catra...it hasn't been for a while. I'm doing too much, and *you're* doing *way* too much, and I hired Mycel to help out. Oh, hi Mycel!" The queen - who Mycel hasn't seen since their interview, and barely saw then - waves. Mycel, reeling from what they just heard and thoroughly out of their depth, waves meekly back.

"I…" Catra pauses, then says quietly, "You should have asked me."

"I did! I asked if you wanted to help me with hiring!"

"No I…" Something must click in her mind, because Catra sits back down on the chair *hard*. It sends her plummeting into the floof once more, and there's another round of tail-lashing splutter

before she once again emerges. "You meant *for me!?* I didn't realize you meant *for me!* I just didn't want to get stuck all day interviewing *your* new personal assistant!" Her voice goes abruptly subdued, "This...this is a bad idea, Sparkles."

"What, fighting in front of your staff that you've apparently been neglecting because you weren't listening when I told you about them? Sorry, Mycel, this isn't very professional."

"No! I mean yes, I mean…I shouldn't…what if I..." Catra opens her mouth like she has something more earnest to say, then stops herself to give Mycel a glance that turns quickly into a glare. When she turns her attention back to the screen, she's all tense muscles and hard words. "I don't need any help."

Mycel's heart sinks into their stomach, as heavy and unavoidable as Queen Glimmer's voice is light and distracted when she says, "Sure you do. And you better get used to it - at the rate we're growing, we're going to eventually need an org chart and at least one more tier of management, so you're going to get *another* promotion and…" Catra's back is to Mycel, so Mycel can't see her face, but something on it makes Queen Glimmer stop and focus and say instead, "Look, I promise I'll communicate better, next time." Catra makes a noise, but Queen Glimmer pushes on with, "But for now, you can't expect to both prepare my notes and be on— hey, wait, weren't you supposed to be with Adora and Bow?"

Senior Counselor Catra shakes herself just a little, then says in an unsettled tone, "Wow, you *have* been busy. It didn't work out, whatever, point is that I don't *want*—"

"Ah, fuck, meeting time! Have fun, you two!"

"Glimmer! You can't—"

The screen goes black. Senior Counselor Catra glares at it like she can shatter it with just her eyes. Her cat creature is curled up under her chair, small and red and spiky.

They stay there for long enough that Mycel decides to take matters into their own hands, albeit after an equally long process of stressed internal dithering. They can't quite eradicate the shake from their voice when they say quietly, "I can...I can walk you through my notes. Before I go."

"I don't need your notes," Senior Counselor Catra says coldly. Her voice is oddly detached.

Mycel has never talked back to a superior in their life, for the record. Now, they say, "I spent all week on—"

"Don't care."

Mycel grits their teeth. "You're going to need to—"

"I'm really not."

"So what?" Mycel bursts out - and, okay, you know what? Maybe they *are* bitter. Maybe *Senior Counselor Catra* has been *really fucking rude,* and now - "I'm supposed to what, disappear? I've been working *constantly* for *weeks* and you're telling me—"

"I'm *telling you*," Catra swings around in her chair so violently that bits of fluff break off into the air with the motion, "to get—"

Mycel just presses through, voice escalating over hers, "—everything I've been working on, everything I've been *asked* to work on—"

"—out! I don't *care* what Sparkles said, I've done the command thing before, and all I did was—"

"—is just, what? Some worthless, disposable crap? Right, you can just toss it out! And while you're at it, how about my *whole job*, and hey, *me too*. Like, *what* is your—"

That's when Mycel realizes the only voice in the room, anymore, is their own.

And the thing is: Mycel doesn't have the most developed predator response.

It's something they learn about, in Erelandia - they're a cautious people more by education than by instinct, since somewhat poisonous folks like Mycel aren't really designed to *run away* from danger. It's not a big deal, really, outside of some vigilance lessons and the worst day of sex ed - the whole *be careful around non-Erelandian partners with particular inclinations* speech is a terrible thing to hear from the middle-grade instructor who also coaches your puffball team, but that's about it. But moments like this, Mycel realizes with stark clarity that they're not a creature with the concept of *prey* in their blood, and that maybe if they were they would have stopped yelling at the *very angry and allegedly violent* woman they're alone in a room with before it reached this point.

Because Senior Counselor Catra has gone utterly silent mid-sentence, and she's still all claws and teeth, every sharp piece of her now rigid on the edge of her seat. At some point her alien companion has switched from large-and-red-and-growling - and oh *shit,* how the *fuck* was Mycel shouting at *that* - to small and blue and as still as Catra herself. The tenseness is more terrifying than the anger, because at least when she was mad Mycel knew what was *happening*, but now she's quiet and indecipherable and her eyes are wide, like she just got zapped by lightning, and it occurs to Mycel that they just *shouted* at their *boss*. Not just any boss, but *Senior Counselor Catra,* who is less likely to fire them than she is to *murder* them, and they scramble frantically to mitigate the damage with, "I didn't mean— I'm so sorry, so, *so*, sorry, that was *so* out of line, please don't fire me, I'm just going to go aw—"

"Stop."

Mycel stops.

"Give that to me."

Mycel turns, slowly, away from the door and back to the room. They're just a step away from where Catra is still seated at the table, still tense and stock-still and unnerving, now with a hand out expectantly as she nods sharply at Mycel's tablet of notes.

"I-I didn't mean—" Mycel starts.

"Give it." Catra says.

Mycel gives it to her.

"Sit." Catra says.

Mycel sits.

Mycel also shakes a little, heart pounding while they go through a frenetic, rapid-fire analysis of where the fuckall they're going to find another job, and also how they're going to get home to Erelandia if they get stranded on *a whole other planet* when they're *fired*, which they are *definitely about to be*, and also where a person even gets an eyepatch for when Catra *claws out their eye*, because rumor has it she's *done that before*. All the while Senior Counselor Catra scrolls down the summary of their notes for tomorrow's presentation, and then Mycel's thinking about the bit towards the bottom that they hadn't had time to organize for someone else's eyes yet, and *oh shit* does it still say *[note to self: clean this the fuck up]* in brackets at the bottom? Shitshitshit*shit.*

Their stress - which, honestly, isn't new, it's been various degrees from simmering to boiling since the moment Senior Counselor Catra walked in - goes into absolute overdrive when the woman calmly puts aside Mycel's notes, instead pulling a crumpled, mostly blank piece of paper to her and bending over it busily with a pen in her hand.

Mycel can't see what she's writing, but it doesn't matter, because Catra starts speaking a moment later. "I will not lie to you," she says, then waves at Mycel's notes without looking up, "this all? It's not perfect. But *worthless*," She lingers over the word, like it

leaves a bad taste she can't help continuing to lick out of her own mouth. Mycle watches her nervously, but she doesn't look up, even when she says, "Worthless, it's not. We can work on it."

That *we* rings in Mycel's head, and they know their mouth is gaping. Catra finally looks up, looks Mycel in the eyes with an unreadable face as she slides the slip of paper she's been writing on across the table. "It's not worthless, and neither are you. And I'm going to do my best to make sure you never need to use this, but...here." She taps a clawed nail on the page.

It's a long, hanging moment before Mycel can tear their gaze away from the intensity of Senior Counselor Catra's and look down. When they do, they find that the page is crude and crumpled and brief, as notes go, but the words are clearly legible in thick, bold pen strokes. They're contained in a big round speech bubble, which is attached to a doodle that looks like it could be a version of Mycel; in the other corner of the page is a doodle of Catra's own face, cartoonishly angry in a manner far more comical and less dignified than Mycel would ever have thought the woman could conceptualize herself. The words themselves read: *I, Counselor Mycel, am totally approved to tattle to Catra's superpowered girlfriend when she's a jerk, and I should show her this if she gets pissy about it.* Beneath that, it's dated and signed.

Catra is saying something about Mycel's bullet points on potential metaphors for explaining magic use, but all Mycel can see are the words on this stupid slip of paper. They interrupt her, saying quietly, "I...probably shouldn't have yelled."

"No, no." There's a hint of what might be laughter in Catra's voice, "The yelling was fair. But let's...not do it again."

Mycel looks at their notes strewn across the table, says shakily, "And, uh. It's not...it's not a *masterpiece*, or anything. I don't want you to think *I* think...I mean, I know you have all this experience, and obviously I don't, so it's probably not—"

Catra cuts them off with a hand - not on Mycel’s arm, but next to it. She taps her claw on the table twice without touching Mycel at all, and Mycel takes the implicit order to meet her eyes. She smiles, and it transforms her face into something kind.

“You’ll get better at it,” Catra says. She pauses for a moment, and then she adds, “and so will I.”

Chapter End Notes

This is the most fantasy thing I have ever written because it involves being able to shout your shit boss into being a better person. V v cathartic; Do Not Try This At Home.

I am still posting!! I still exist! I'm just slow. Life, etc. Thank you to everyone who's made it this far; the next part IS coming, but once again I must find the time to edit the hell out of it.

TWO: +4 years, Expo for New Technologies & Emerging Research (ENTER), Eridani

Chapter Summary

Bow's kind of a big deal.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is for anyone who has spent the previous chapters going "goddamn Bow deserves a raise and also some freaking appreciation he puts up with so much."

So: me. This chapter's for me. Also maybe you folks, but definitely me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

TWO

+4 years, Expo for New Technologies & Emerging Research (ENTER), Eridani

The problem with primary sources, Teau thinks, is that no one understands the importance of the moment they're in. It comes up frustratingly often. Teau will be reading through an ancient notebook or listening to an old recording or examining an eons-old painting, and suddenly he's struck all over again by how *annoying* it is, the way people don't think about the future. They write diaries filled with nicknames and inside jokes, pen letters with no names at all, fail wildly to label photographs with even so much as the date. They assume they'll remember how to decode those things, or their kids will, or their grandkids will, and never think about their grandkids' children's children's children's new friends from across the universe, who want to *know*.

See: the study of historical architecture - Teau thinks this a lot, and says it almost as often - is a magnificent endeavour to devote

one's life to. It's the kind of thing that can take you all around Etheria and then (and he's still not over this) to the *stars beyond*, even if just before that it kept you ten years at the bottom of the Salineas sea seeing the same ruins and three colleagues every day. It's deep and majestic and enriching - but also, quite horribly, it is at its core the study of *people.* Where they want to live and work and meet, what they care about and what their goals and dreams and fears are. Where they place their foundations and what they figure out how to build on top. And *people*, Teau finds on a daily basis, are ridiculous and brilliant and obnoxious and - crucially - *extremely shitty note takers.*

"Teau?"

Take this, for example. Here amid these mountainous stacks of jumbled pre-Despondos Etherian literature he'd talked his way into, it should be his greatest find: a first hand account from the wife of an ancient, sub-aquatic, *pre-Salinean* architect. *Should be,* because all the names are indicated in a jumble of initial-only notations, it's peppered with slang Teau can't even begin to decipher, and apparently she didn't feel the need to put a *date* anything at all, choosing instead to denote time based on entirely unplaceable personal events.

"Teau."

Which is really *incredibly annoying,* isn't it? And the worst part is, he can't even blame her. She probably figured she'd remember, who AQ was or when AZ and J got married, and from context Teau is *pretty sure* but not *totally sure* that *AZ* is actually famed ancient interior designer—

"Teau!"

A vague part of Teau registers his name, and he absently files it away under deal-with-that-after-this-next-page. Except then a hand waves in front of the *current page*, obscuring the text,and he snaps, "Sure, yeah, sure," shoving at his brother's hand as he does.

“Are you even listening to me?” Bow asks, and he sounds annoyed.

Which, for the record, Teau does *not* have time for. “Uh...sure,” Teau says, then quickly goes through the ambient prattle he’d been quite handily filtering out up to this point. He comes up with, “Traps and...spearmint and myrtle? Bow, did you always like gardening?”

Bow sighs, rubbing at his forehead. “*Entrapta.* And *Experimental Murder Mode*, which is what I convinced her to *remove* from the robot settings list, so we probably won’t get kicked out of the Expo. Which is good, because...”

He keeps talking. And Teau tries to keep his gaze away from the journal, he really does, but—

“Teau!”

“Uh, yeah,” Teau says absently as his eyes skim to the end of the page, which talks a lot about a Salinean Shopping Mall - which, *ha!*, take *that*, he *knew* it was something like that. Site of religious worship, his *ass*. Well probably. If it was the right place. It sounds a lot like it is, except the geography described seems pretty low, which might actually help him pinpoint when it was built up as long as the next page—

“Do you know what you’re agreeing to?” Bow asks, and Teau pulls his hand back from it’s motion towards the book. Teau knows his brother’s arms are crossed without even having to look, mostly because that’s a mannerism the entire family has picked up from Lance, even if Bow’s *tone* is all George. Which is weird, hearing their dad’s voice out of his baby brother’s mouth.

Weird enough for Teau to at least glance up guiltily in response. “Uh…”

Bow is standing awkwardly amid the piles of books here behind the bookseller’s booth, and sure enough his arms are crossed. “My

presentation," he says, "on the Magic-o-Meter 2.0 and the new compatibility device and Entrapta's robots. Are you coming?"

"...Uh...sure?" Depending, of course, on how long it takes to read through this journal, and to cross reference the events and persons referenced in it with the rest of his notes, and maybe get through the rest of this box of material because if he stops mid-way he might be totally lost when he gets back, and— "Hey, uh...when was your session again?"

"Oh, come *on*," Bow replies, sounding plaintive, "you *promised."*

"We've only been talking for ten minutes! When did I promise?"

"I've been talking to *you* for the last *half hour*, whether or not you want to participate. Or care." There's an odd note to Bow's voice, one that Teau could probably parse if his mind wasn't saturated in the life of Bilda Hass, ancient architect, and her avid diarist of a wife. His eyes are drifting back to the page when Bow adds, "Plus, I know you promised our dads you'd watch, they told me."

Dammit, that's true.

"...look, Bow." Teau says, trying to be subtle about turning the journal page, "I'll...try. But I've got so much to go through, and I'm sure the Eridanian who agreed to bring it out for me can't wait forever."

"It's one session, Teau! Not *forever*. I *never* get to show you guys what I do! I've got a seat reserved for you and everything." Bow's eyes are really, really big, and he's chewing his lip, and for a moment Teau is afraid they're going to have to have a bit of a *moment*, and also that he's going to have to explain to his baby brother how frankly ridiculous it is to be *saving a seat* for someone at a *research presentation*, at least when you're new to this kind of thing. It's not exactly the Enchanted Grotto. But then Bow lets out a big sigh and subsides into a more understanding, "But I...I get it. You're busy. I'll—"

He’s interrupted by a shout and a crash from outside the exhibition booth, followed by a loud shriek that sounds more gleeful than anything else.

“...Entrapta,” Bow says with a sigh. Teau’s not sure if that’s a device or a person or what, but does appreciate the relief he feels when Bow says, “I’m...gonna handle that.”

Bow might vault over the table and into some kind of fray, then, but Teau barely registers it as he drifts back to the journal before him. He’s so engrossed that he only absently notices the change of the sounds around him from loud-bustling-people to loud-shouting-destruction to silence, and then back to loud-bustling-people again. He’s sitting on the floor behind the Eridanian book vendor’s booth and is about a quarter of the way through the journal when something manages to interrupt him, and it’s the owner of the booth itself.

“Whoo-ee, that was a *doozy!*” She says, tripping cheerfully back to sit at the chair behind the booth’s main table. “Did you see that?”

“Hmm?” Teau questions absently, turning a page.

“The murder robot! It was all like *raaaa* and the Etherians were like *zwoooosh* and then the robots were like *nooooo* and it was *badass*. Would have been more badass if I didn’t spend it hiding behind a coffee carafe - but hey! I got the last cup! Even if it’s shitty and lukewarm!” Teau hums, then turns another page and hopes his companion’s done. “Hey, you’re Etherian.” No such luck. “Any chance you know that crew?...Though I guess that’s rude, it’s not like all Etherians have to know each other or—”

Because it’s good form to be nice to the lady letting you peruse her collection of very old, very rare, very specialized writings, Teau responds. He doesn’t manage to be entirely undistracted, but he still gets out a clear, “Uh, yeah. One of them’s my brother.”

A soft *thump* makes Teau look up, and he finds the vendor frantically pulling out a towel to clear up a puddle of brown liquid before it can find its way to the books. He sees the little paper coffee cup on its side on the floor, and his nose quickly corroborates the assumption that she dropped her coffee.

She should be more careful, Teau thinks, seeing as she works with books and all. But these are *important*, so it's enough to make him put his journal down and help shift precious paper out of the way as she mops up the spill. When they've determined that everything can be saved, he's stopped from returning to his book with a question.

"So, hey, uh...so. So...your brother. Is Bow of Bright Moon?" She taps her talons together almost nervously; the little vestigial wings at her shoulders flutter a bit.

Teau blinks. "Uh...yeah?"

"Bow of Bright Moon, master archer and technician?"

"Uh...yes." That is what Bow does, right? Dammit, this is what he gets for skipping the holidays, but also - *bottom of the ocean. Ancient ruins.* (There's a voice in his head that says that shouldn't have stopped him from calling more often; it sounds a lot like his dad and he'd like it to *shut up*, please and thanks.)

The bookseller's eyes - too wide by Etherian standards already - go even wider, and there's an undercurrent of awe to her voice when she says, "Bow who fought with She-Ra to save the planet Etheria from the empire of Horde Prime?"

"Yeah," Teau replies, because yeah, that's accurate. He wasn't really around for most of that - perk of spending most of your time off-grid at remote ruins is that you don't have to stress too much when your planet's invaded, since you'll mostly just hear the gloss of it after the fact. But yeah, Teau knows Bow was involved in that, along with his girlfriend the queen (which is still *wild*) and the bad-tempered woman with the tail and She-Ra. Oh, yeah,

right, Teau thinks, She-Ra's a pretty big deal. That must be what this is about.

"Bow, inventor of the Magic-o-Meter and co-creator of the Magic Assessment Bots?"

That's...specific. Teau is hesitant as he replies, "...Sure…"

She leans in closer, "Bow, who single-handedly wrangled the Ice-Beast of Celad with nothing but his wits, two trick arrows, and a paperclip!?"

What? "Uh...I...guess?...I uh. I take it you're here for his talk?"

"He's *presenting?"*

Teau stares at her, then asks slowly, "...You didn't know?"

The woman leans back, looking delighted. "Oh, nah, dude. I just come to sell; I never look at the program these days. I keep one to give people directions, though - let me find it."

She fumbles with one of her inventory boxes to produce a crumpled-up program, which she starts to flip through. As she does, Teau asks slowly, "So you're...not a fan? Of my brother's?"

She shrugs. "I mean, he's cool, but not particularly. I just watch the news. Ah! Here it is - oh, shit, it's about to start, we should head down!"

Teau is in something of a daze as he's tugged up and along, making sure he snags the journal to bring along, then waiting while the book vendor puts up a *Will Return Later* sign and activates some sort of alien forcefield around the merchandise. It surprises him, because there are still plenty of people who could buy from her on the vending floor, but she doesn't seem to begrudge the loss of business in her enthusiasm.

He thinks she might just be like that - particularly enthusiastic, that is - but he finds his faith in that conviction quickly shaken.

They take two lefts, go down a staircase and come upon a large crowd of equally enthusiastic attendees, filtering into a room while chattering. That's not particularly strange, but what *is* surprising is just how *excited* everyone is, and it only gets more overwhelming when his new friend - Sella, he's learned by now, whether he wanted to or not - drops into conversation that Teau's the speaker's brother. After that, he finds himself quite thoroughly swept along, suddenly accosted by five different aliens with a thousand questions about a thousand things he *knows nothing about*.

Sella tugs him to the volunteer staff for the room, who uses a tentacle to wave them forward and deposits Teau in a seat at the front of the room. She even goes so far as to unfold an extra metal chair to accommodate Sella, who seems to have decided to use her new association to snag a seat - because the room is indeed full. There's an air of *expectation,* like everyone is there to see a performance rather than a research talk.

Teau notices all of this in fits and starts, between the barrage of questions and introductions he himself is subject to.

"...I don't know if he did that...a *magnifying arrow*, I mean, I guess?...*caught her mid-space!? Really!?*..."

Sella laughs at him, when he gets a breather, slapping his back. "*How* did I not realize *Bow from Etheria* would be speaking!" She says, "I can't believe no one mentioned it - though I guess I can, since all I've done since the Expo began has been hide from robots and talk to you. And of course *you* wouldn't have mentioned it - all this must be pretty normal for you, being family and all."

Teau laughs nervously, because no, it's *really not*. He has a wild, frantic thought of *does the rest of the family know about this!?* followed by the mental response of *of course they know about this*, followed by a slightly unhinged recall of Sella's voice so very casual when she said *I just watch the news*.

Teau does not watch the news. It's depressing. Roe and Do and his dads - all quite avid about current events - give him a hard time for it, but in his defense, he never realized it might turn up...all this.

At the podium, Bow is speaking with a woman with a mass of purple hair. For all his earlier nervousness and his current slight dishevelment, he looks at ease up there beside a multitude of complex technology festooned with colorful beeping lights, a screwdriver in one hand as he roots through the back panel of a blocky-looking robot while the woman's pigtails run along the thing's other side, adjusting metal pieces and brushing debris from its surface.

It's a dissonantly casual moment for where it's held, which is at the front of a room filled to the brim. Teau looks around again, noticing that people are *standing in the back*, before a sharp murmur of awe through the crowd causes him to spin back around to the stage. He looks over in time to see the pink cloud dissipate around Bow's royal girlfriend, and Teau gathers from the whispers that Eridani only just developed any form of *magic* to make that kind of thing possible. Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon uses it only to brush a kiss across Bow's cheek, murmur something in his ear, then disappear again in another pink poof.

Bow steps up to the podium, straightening his cropped jacket and rubbing a cloth over his oil-stained hands. "Robots, am I right?" He says, and a laugh travels gently through the space. Bow grins apologetically and brings up a hand to scratch sheepishly at the back of his head, adding, "Uh, hey everyone, I'm Bow! It turns out *Experimental Chores Mode*, is more...*active*...than I thought. We'll start in a moment, I promise."

He steps away, back to the robot and the purple-haired woman - who is waving at the audience with the tendrils of her hair, though she snaps back into single-minded focus at something Bow says. Out of habit, Teau's fingers move to open the journal in his hands. He glances down at it, and then back up, then back down. It'd been easy enough to fold it open now, skim a few more lines;

maybe even cover it with a conference program so he can keep reading once the talk begins.

He looks back up.

There's a video Teau's family likes to share around, has since the apocalypse came and failed to take. It's of Bow, and he's giving a speech - Teau doesn't remember the words; he was at the bottom of the Salineas sea when it happened and then he was preoccupied the first and fifth and tenth time his dads played the recording at the holidays. It's a video of Bow as a projection, and in it he's giving a speech; judging by the relative size of the trees in the film, the hologram of him is unthinkably tall as he gives it. Teau's always known, on some level, that it must have been impressive in the moment, but on a little tablet pad screen it doesn't look like much at all. A had-to-be-there kind of thing, Teau always thought, if he thought about it at all.

Teau hasn't thought about that video in ages, but now he does, as he looks at the stage. Bow is back at the podium, fussing with a cup of water and a display of screens before clearing his throat. He doesn't look like Teau's baby brother, right now: he's older than the Bow who lives in Teau's head. This one isn't trying for a beard so much as succeeding at one, dressed in a formal, midriff-baring, bow-and-arrow patterned jacket-and-pants combination that Teau struggles to imagine fitting in their childhood home, but which...works, for Bow. His voice is strong and low - lower than Teau expects, for all they were just talking earlier that day - and solid, authoritative even when it's casual and light. He's confident and warm and a *public figure*, apparently, with a presence that fills the room and a dignity to match.

Teau looks at the journal in his hands - the unvarnished account of a woman who watched history happen, and was smart enough to write it down, even if she didn't always do so transparently. It may contain amazing new information, for his field and his career and the way he understands that time and those places in Etheria.

And he looks up, away from the journal. As he does, he sees Bow's eyes catch on him in the audience, and the grin that spreads across his brother's face - bright and surprised, joyous and grateful - makes him the person Teau knows, has always known: the kid who used to look so awkward in the library and the boy who liked to experiment with stick-throwing devices in the backyard, the man who begged him to come to this session and the other man standing up there on the stage. Something new and not-so-new after all, built high on a familiar foundation. His little brother, a thousand feet tall.

Bilda Hass isn't going anywhere, Teau decides, placing the journal down gently by his feet. He digs around in his pocket for a writing implement; borrows a fresh expo-issued notepad from Sella, who seems to have a small collection of them in her bag. When he puts his pen to the page, he starts with the date.

Chapter End Notes

> Teau's full name is Chateau; gold star to anyone who can guess Sella's.

ONE: +1 year, Bi-Annual Tri-Galactic Conference of Aligned Planets, Albir

Chapter Summary

Foreplay, but make it educational.

Chapter Notes

Sellabooka. You are all correct, it is Sellabooka. I will not apologize.

Moving on.

I expended a truly enormous amount of energy on editing this chapter, 75% of which went into making exactly one extremely stupid joke work. I think this says a lot about me as a person.

This is the catradora chapter, so if you're skipping through this fic looking for that...here it is. Also there's wonderful fanart for it from the Big Bang, which I'll link at the bottom. Also also this includes a particular moment that I have been waiting a *goddamn year* to show the internet, so needless to say I'm very excited to be posting.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

ONE

+1 year, Bi-Annual Tri-Galactic Conference of Aligned Planets, Albir

You should never meet your heroes, they'd told Quidet before she left home. Now, she knows why.

What she'd *thought* - before she'd made it to her destination, before *today* - was that it was merely a matter of distance. No

academic would be expected to resist *this* - the millenia-dead subject of Quidet's years of research, suddenly appeared out of nowhere - if it had happened next door. But the universe is an endless place, and this tiny scrap of dubious whispering had come from a solar system far, far away. The kind of far with no direct transport or lifeline home; the kind of far that's too far off for most Tentaclean travelers to bother to return.

And so they'd said it, again and again; her mother first, worried and anxious, then Quidet's brother, who'd thought she was mad for devoting her whole life to what he derisively called *fairy tales* and thinks she's madder still for hitch-hiking her way through the cosmos to follow them. Her friends had all but held an intervention; her advisor had pointed out that she could wait a while, see if this ostensible *She-Ra* would come to her, given time. Even that jerk Phalo from the department had told her to stay home, adding *it's probably a fake, anyway* with a sneer that made Quidet think he's actually jealous - after all, it's not like his Him-man or whatever was about to turn up. *You should never meet your heroes*, they'd each intoned - trite and simple and gentle, probably passed around as *a good line* between conspiring friends and family - in a way that really just amounts to *you shouldn't leave, not for this.*

She's glad they can't see her now, here after nearly a year of spaceships and shuttles and awkward requests for a ride from strangers, of too many spaceports that somehow all feel exactly the same and way, way, *way* too many utterances of the corrective phrase, "*Ten-ta*-cleez*, rhymes with* cheese," which is an old rhyme she'd never expected to *use* before all this, let alone come to hate. She's glad no one she knows gets to watch her stand around in this room-that-is-somehow-also-a-forest (aliens are weird) with two dozen other session attendees, all young insofar as she can tell (alien biology is weird), all with a variety of athletic gear covering their bodies, which are all too hairy and disturbingly low-limbed to Quidet's Tentaclean sensibilities (aliens are really, *really* weird). She's glad her friends and family can't see her now, because pretty sure they'd feel vindicated, the lot of them.

(Well, the lot of them except Cala-Marie, who hadn't cautioned Quidet at all. Cala, who'd just reached out to put one tentacle against Quidet's membrane and asked her to *write me, please*, even though they both knew it would be mere weeks before she was too far away for the messages to send. Cala, who Quidet hadn't asked to come along, just like Cala hadn't asked Quidet to come back to her, because that wasn't the kind of promise they could make to each other, back when Quidet packed her bags and disappeared into the stars. Cala-Marie, who Quidet's not thinking about, except for how she always is.)

All of which to say: Quidet had been cautioned about what might happen if she left home on a years-long foray to meet a mythical being, and she's mad about it. Because Adora of Etheria is...

"...the traditional way to hold it! At least, I think it's traditional. It's what we did in the Horde, anyway, though I guess that isn't the most— I do have a card on it somewhere here, if I can just...shit! I mean damn! Fuck, I mean, uh. Whoops. Whoops is good. I did *not* mean to drop that..."

...not. She's just...*not.*

Oh, she's competent, more or less. She's quite capable, insofar as Quidet can tell - not that Quidet is an expert in battle arts, but she knows a thing or two from Cala's phase a few years back, even if none of it is entirely applicable to all this alien anatomy. No, Adora has a solid form and clear instructions, when she can manage her obvious nerves enough to present them. Pretty, if you're into that whole bipedal thing, certainly enthusiastic, seemingly intelligent. But she's...young. Quidet can barely concentrate on the series of "Etherian combat moves!" (Adora's words, exceedingly chirpy, a bit exhausting), and she's never really been one for combat...anything, really, outside supporting Cala. Quidet's a scholar, through and through, and came here for one thing. One *person*, who is shuffling about awkwardly, tongue sticking out the corner of her mouth in concentration as she struggles to find a way to hold her training staff and a stack of small cardstock squares at the same time. She looks nothing at all like the images

that had brought Quidet to this place: scattered shots of Adora, the girl who they say is She-Ra, looking seriously into the camera with her chin high and her eyes flashing, shoulder pads nearly up to her ears and a hand fisted at her side and a sword - She-Ra's sword, the Sword of Protection, a symbol of power and hope and magic, depicted and discussed and analyzed in eons-worth of records - confident in the air.

"...which I *know* is not very professional, but I promise I'm good at this! Really, really good! I, uh, okay so the next thing I wanted to show you was...shi— *whoops*. *Whoops*, where *is* that note…"

Probably a fake, anyway, Phalo's voice rings in Quidet's ears, as she watches Adora find what she's looking for with an "ah-ha!" Adora throws her hands in the air in triumph and then smiles sheepishly when the only response is a room of blank stares, and it's charming. Cute, certainly. But not, well.

Not *She-Ra*.

Because Quidet - Quidet *knows* She-Ra. Quidet might be the one person left in the *universe* who knows She-Ra - a dramatic statement, maybe, but she's yet to find anyone else willing to wade through planet upon planet of obscure pre-Hordian libraries and texts and myths, dusty tomes and glitching, halting footage of ancient holograms. Quidet has nearly a decade of research on a tech pad in her bag, probably her most precious possession, full of notes and sources and guesses but mostly of *stories*, tales of She-Ra the warrior, She-Ra the peacemaker, the leader, the mentor, She-Ra larger than life and full of magic, ready to step out of the legends of the past pulling a planet in her wake and ready, Quidet had let herself believe, to step into Quidet's very real, very mundane little life. She-Ra who was supposed to be an *experience*, who was supposed to be amazing and bright and unbelievable, and who wasn't supposed to be— to be—

"*Bo-ring.*"

Sing-song words jolt Quidet out of her thoughts and cut Adora's ramble off into silence. The voice is an entirely new one, and Quidet turns along with the nearly two dozen other attendees to follow it. It's easy enough to find the source: a woman, hip against the door in an insouciant lounge, with big triangular ears and a lashing tail - which is one more appendage than anyone else in the forest-room, so Quidet's inclined to approve. She has a vaguely amorphous, blue-red cat-like creature at her feet, which presently slinks inside to curl up in the artificial shade of a tree.

"Catra."

For the second time in as many moments, Quidet and the rest of the class turn to a new voice - except it's not new at all, Quidet realizes. It's Adora's, and she's leaning on her staff, eyes on the newcomer and eyebrows up to her hairline.

She sounds...different. Looks different, too.

Quidet can't put her tentacle on it, exactly. It's something to the way she's holding herself, now, to the glint in her eyes, something jaunty in the hand she places on her own hip. None of it *should* be distinct from how she was a moment ago, but Quidet thinks, a there-and-gone blink of a thought, that this woman maybe *could* be—

"Hey, Adora," the woman in the doorway - Catra, apparently - says. She pushes off the frame, kicking the door closed behind her as she grins with sharp, sharp teeth, and Quidet can't quite shake the feeling that they've been closed in the room with something dangerous, though she's not quite sure if it's this woman or if it's this new Adora or if it's the immediate, searing crackle of the air between the pair of them. Quidet also can't tell if the words are goading or threatening when the new woman notes with clearly affected boredom, "Heard you all the way down the hall. You're boring them to *tears*, princess."

"I am *not!"* is Adora's snap of a reply.

"Yeah, you totally are. She's bored, he's bored - are you bored?" Catra advances through the group, asking her question to a man at the edge of the group. His eyes skitter back and forth in confusion, and he's just opening his mouth to reply when Catra cuts him off, still looking at Adora, "See, he's bored."

Adora's eyes narrow for just a moment, and then she sighs. "*You're* bored, Catra. Is that what happened? Did Glimmer kick you out of her session about the alliance?"

"No!" The word is quick, defensive. "I'm here to *help."*

"Oh, so *Bow* kicked you out of Glimmer's session about the alliance."

Catra splutters and glares a glare so fierce that it makes Quidet worried for Adora. They've drifted closer as they've talked, but Catra's still in the midst of the participant group, so Quidet can see up-close as her scowl deepens and sharp claws slide out of her fingers. Quidet shifts nervously, and she doesn't think she's the only one.

So she'd maybe gotten a little deep into her research, a little *too* invested into the myth of She-Ra. She's not sure that's bad enough to deserve to get stuck in the middle of whatever...*this*...is.

It seems, however, that she doesn't have a choice. Because, "Oh, come on," Catra says, tugging a practice staff away from one of the other attendees and advancing, voice concerningly pleasant even if everything else about her is menacing, "you're showing them, like, *baby stuff*. This is a strategy session! Let them see a real *fight*."

Adora looks down at the few notecards still in her hand, and whatever had just filled her - whatever ineffable, brightening quality Quidet still couldn't articulate - drains away like rain down a gutter, replaced by the same nervous insecurity from before. "But," she says, quietly this time, "I only prepar—"

Catra, now at the front of the forest-room, taps a claw in the center of the notecard. Quidet can't quite tell, but she thinks it might make a hole there. Every inch of Catra - from claw to stance to voice - screams *challenge* when she says, "You're better at improv."

Adora looks up.

Quidet's not sure what passes between the two women. They clearly know each other, and there seems to be history there - colleagues, maybe, by the content they've spoken to each other, though the taunting familiarity between them says they'd have to be old ones, and they're too young for that. Foes, apparently, if the tense edge of the conversation really is animosity, though she hopes they'll keep it civil enough for the sake of the conference.

Whatever they are, something clearly happens between them, because a moment later Adora's shoulders draw back and her spine straightens, the smirk sliding across her mouth as much a *challenge accepted* as words could ever be.

"Fine," Adora says, and throws the notecards over her shoulder, where they scatter on the forest-room floor. Two dozen voices sigh with various degrees of relief; Quidet is slightly embarrassed to say she's among them. Quidet is even more embarrassed when she realizes Adora heard; she looks past Catra's shoulder and quirks an eyebrow at the forest-room at large. "Okay then," she says. She steps forward to address the room, shoulder-checking Catra with understated belligerence on the way, "A demonstration. So the thing to know about a *real* fight, is that every opponent is going to be different," she speaks smoothly, a far cry from how she'd begun the session, "it's good if you can know what you're dealing with: if they're fast or slow, physically strong, extremely methodical - clones are like that, they all fight the same - or—"

"Behind you!" An attendee shouts, but it's both too late and unnecessary. While Quidet - and, presumably, most of her fellow attendees - had been watching Adora, Catra had lined herself up

to spring from behind, staff aimed directly for Adora's head mid-speech.

It might have been a harsh, shattering blow, if it had met her skull - but it didn't. Instead, it met a whirling Adora, who'd spun so quickly that Quidet only processed it now that the attack was already intercepted, staff-to-staff. The two women meet glares over their weapons as Adora finishes, through gritted, grinning teeth, "—*treacherous*."

Adora shoves with her staff, and Catra lets herself be pushed back, sniggering as she dances closer to the denser places of the forest-room's tree line. They begin to circle each other, widely, and Adora notes: "Rude*."*

Catra's snigger becomes a full on laugh, albeit a slightly nasty one. "Never said I couldn't," she taunts. "Now, you gonna bore me all over again?"

"Wouldn't dream of it," Adora says, and charges.

Quidet is more certain than ever that she's stumbled across something bigger than just an educational demonstration, because these two women - they might be trying to kill each other. Quidet is still no expert, but the punches don't seem pulled at all. Catra ditches her staff early in the fight, but when she misses an open-handed swipe with her claws they go solidly through a tree; Adora's staff digs furrows in the hard earth deep enough to make Quidet gulp. She wonders if this is maybe more dangerous than she'd thought, if she should be stepping away and getting one of the conference's sparse guards to come break up a battle one poor dodge away from lethal.

But she doesn't, because as violent as it is - and it *is* violent, the dance of them - it's also riveting. Catra sticks mostly to shadows and trees, using blind spots and quick, darting movements to slide under Adora's attacks, as well as to make her own before retreating back out of sight. For her part, any sweetness Adora had shown in her stumbling attempts to lead a structured session

about basic fighting moves is replaced by incisive scans to identify Catra's locations, followed by brutally efficient campaigns to draw her out and *keep her out*, ones that leave both women panting and snarling.

You should maybe never meet your heroes, Quidet thinks, because they might be fucking *terrifying*.

She doesn't know how long it goes on. A minute, or ten - or maybe she's been standing here, hearts pounding like *she's* the one fighting, for the better part of the day. All she knows is that one moment her tentacles are twitching in a sympathetic urge to help block close call after close call, and the next the battle - doesn't end, exactly, and doesn't pause, but reaches an inflection point. Catra goes to dart behind a tree, Adora throws herself bodily forward, and the strange alien cat-creature Catra entered with only barely has enough time to leap away into the treetop before Adora slams Catra into its trunk. Catra's agility only allows her to spin in Adora's grip, try for another claw-swipe that Adora catches by the wrist, slamming the offending hand back against the bark beside Catra's proud, snarling face.

It's the first moment of battle that Catra has been more-or-less stationary, and it draws the attention back to her main weapons, which is to say her hands. The one against the tree is stretched wide, long fingers splayed and crooked and tensed, each one ending with a wicked, glittering point.

Quidet's only just made it through a split-second, boggling calculation of just *how lethal* those claws are when she is suddenly, deeply worried about the other set of them. Because Catra's other hand is free, also splayed and five-pronged and sharp, and it's shoving up between her and her captor from below, aimed directly at Adora's belly.

Vicious and quite literally underhanded, it's a move that says she doesn't care if her opponent gets hurt. A detached corner of Quidet's mind begins to compose her statement to security about how she saw her session instructor *gutted*. A set of voices cry out,

reflexive and shocked, and Quidet barely recognizes them as her own and half a dozen of the onlookers', all shouting some form of warning.

As with the beginning of the fight, Adora doesn't even look surprised. In one quick, unerringly deft motion, she drops her staff and uses her now-free hand to meet the upcoming threat, weaving her own fingers into the spaces between Catra's and shoving their combined grip - Adora's palm to the back of Catra's hand - forward into the center of Catra's chest. It's sheer brute strength, Quidet thinks, that lets her redirect Catra's momentum, and the move forces Catra to retract her claws or else shove them into her own skin.

Catra bares her teeth in a growl, and Adora bares her own right back, shoving her whole weight forward to presses Catra even further into the tree.

For a moment, the forest-slash-room is near-silent, everything giving way to panting breaths from the two women against the tree, held ones from the onlookers. The attendee next to Quidet lets out a long, shaky exhale, but Quidet can't rip her eyes from the standoff, and she'd bet no one else can, either.

And then, Catra starts to laugh.

She sounds a little deranged, and she wiggles the fingers of the hand trapped by her head, this time a tease instead of a threat. "This feels familiar," she says in a voice that's somehow both very private and deeply theatrical, pitched to carry.

Adora's bared teeth take on the shape of a grin, and it occurs to Quidet that that attack - the one Catra had very nearly landed - yes, it's the act of someone who doesn't care if her opponent gets hurt. Unless, of course, she was absolutely certain it wouldn't connect.

They're having fun*,* Quidet thinks. It's a shock of a thought.

“Out of moves?” Adora asks, false, flirtatious innocence dripping from the words as Catra tries futilely to squirm out of her grip.

Catra stretches her head forward, her face so very close to Adora’s that Quidet wonders again if she should flee the room, now for other reasons entirely. But Catra doesn’t close that last bit of the gap, though her lips move in words Quidet can’t make out. Whatever they are, they leave Adora spluttering and blushing red, her hand maybe going just the tiniest bit lax around Catra’s to allow for—

“Nope!” Adora shouts it, more a yelp than a word as she once again shoves her weight into Catra to keep her immobile. “No way! I *told you* that doesn’t *work* anymore!”

Catra gives an actual, honest-to-goodness *pout*, followed by a full-bodied sigh. Adora has just enough time for a smirk - and the room has just enough time to maybe start to relax, ever so slightly - when Catra breaks any form of peace by darting her head forward once again, this time not bothering to stop her movement when her face reaches Adora’s, then past it.

“Ow!” Adora shouts. Her hands pull back to cradle the left side of her head, and Catra - suddenly freed - scrambles up the tree with another maniacal laugh. “You *bit* me!” Adora shouts after her, somewhere between incredulous and, if Quidet’s reading it right, rueful.

The reply from the tree is silence.

Actual silence, Quidet realizes, even quieter than the one before. Not even the rustling of leaves; not in that tree, or in any other.

It’s like Catra, who has been nothing but disruptive from the moment she stepped in the door, has disappeared from the forest-room in her entirety. Except that’s not possible, is it? The dissonance of the thought makes it eerie.

Eerie for Quidet, that is. Not, apparently, for Adora, who takes it as her own turn to laugh - a low, dark sound, as dark as the

sweat-damp hair stuck to her forehead and the dirt smudged on her face. She's picked up her staff, holding it now at the ready, and her eyes dart around the wooded training ground. Her tense form belies her cocky smile, her dark laugh, the almost gleeful and mocking and certainly condescending way she calls out, "Here, kitty kitty kitty."

One of the watchers - not Quidet, thankfully - lets out a nervous little giggle. It stops almost as soon as it starts, and in its wake is even more quiet.

And then: "Alright, kids, pro-tip," Catra's voice comes from - Quidet whips around wildly with the rest of the students - apparently nowhere at all.

Adora's the only person who doesn't look around, just dropping her head forward briefly with a bit of a groan, "Ugh. We're doing the invisibility thing, are we?"

"It doesn't matter how 'fair' your opponent wants to fight," continues Catra's voice. Quidet still can't quite place it, but she thinks it's definitely coming from above, "fair's a fucking fallacy. You got an advantage? You *use* it. And you use it *first*."

A thump draws Quidet's attention back to Adora, who has - dropped her staff to the ground again, apparently? She's smirking, standing straight up now, one hand on her hip almost casually. "Okay," she calls pleasantly, "how's this for advantage? *For the Honor of*—"

You should never meet your heroes, Quidet thinks it almost frantically this time, heart pounding and thoughts wild, unmoored. She's not sure she wants to, anymore, so very turned around by all of *this*, and yet she wants it more than she's wanted anything in her whole life. A decade of research, forgotten a moment prior, suddenly feels like it's burning in its bag by her feet, Quidet's entire damn dissertation boiled down not just to a single tech pad but to a single hair-raising moment, glowing the way Adora is here and now as she raises her hand into the air and—

Something drops out of a tree, fast and snarling, slamming straight into the glow and cutting off the words.

Quidet lets out a little shriek, and hears the rest of the students and their array of shocked shouts and gasps and shuffles, too. She's about to really run for a guard - not that she knows what they'd *do,* but she has to do *something* - when the light clears, and Quidet knows she's not the only one frozen still by the sight it reveals.

Adora is gone, and in her place is a larger, somehow brighter version of herself, covered full in a suit of white and gold, power clear in her arms and shoulders and legs and otherworldly glowing blue eyes, brighter than Adora's had been by far. She's flat on her back, waves upon waves of ponytailed hair flowing in an unnaturally gold river behind and under her head, a flash of red at her hips where her newly acquired half-skirt is flipped open against the dust of the ground.

Maybe you shouldn't meet your heroes, Quidet thinks, but this - this is everything Quidet had ever wanted. *This* is She-Ra, bright and golden and absolutely magnificent, exactly as Quidet had expected her. And yet, Quidet had never expected to see her prone on her back in the dirt.

The reason for She-Ra's state is sitting astride her, Catra's legs bracketing She-ra's hips and her breaths visibly heaving in her chest. She has She-Ra's head pressed up, crown (of She-Ra's head, but also *actual crown*) kissing the dirt, neck exposed. And at She-Ra's neck, Catra holds a sword. It's long and gleaming and silver, with a gold hilt and a blue gemstone, and it matches the woman on the ground so well that there's no way to deny that it's She-Ra's sword Catra is holding to She-Ra's own vulnerable throat.

Quidet stares. Once again, the only sounds are harsh, panting breaths, this time from Catra alone. She-Ra's breaths come in and out slowly, naturally, even as her head tilts into the dirt.

It’s only because of the silence that they all can hear someone braver than Quidet, from the back, quietly ask: “Can she...do that?”

Quidet has been studying She-Ra for nearly a decade. Quidet knows the answer is *no.*

No, that is not a normal sword. No, it cannot be wielded by anyone other than She-Ra, because it is *part of She-Ra*, *manifested by She-Ra* and also *un-manifested by She-Ra’s will.* Or, possibly, without her will - it’s not like Quidet has that much information. But what records she’s found of the She-Ras thousands of years past make it pretty clear that it’s not like She-Ra can just...casually hand her sword off to anyone else. You can’t hand someone your own tentacle and let them use it, not even if that use is noble, let alone to *hold it to your own neck.*

And yet, that’s where it is right now, before Quidet’s eyes. In Catra’s hands, against She-Ra’s neck.

It’s like the question breaks a spell, because suddenly Catra is scrambling off, stumbling back a few feet with wide eyes locked tight on She-Ra’s sprawl. She doesn’t drop the sword, but her fists do go white-knuckled around it’s hilt.

It occurs to Quidet that Catra might know this shouldn’t be possible, too.

The whole room remains tense, waiting for - something, *anything*, to happen. There’s a nervousness to the air as even the students who don’t understand what just happened seem to recognize at least some portion of its weight, maybe intuit that they have witnessed something that *should not be*.

Only one person appears to be unaffected, and that’s She-Ra herself. She sits up, not even winded, and stands to her full height - which, it turns out, is very, *very* tall - with an unassuming relaxation that’s polar opposite to the pulse of nerves filling every other person in the forest-room. She takes a moment to dust

herself off despite inexplicably appearing not to have collected any dust in the first place, then smiles sunnily at the still-gaping attendee cluster.

"I think that's good for today!" She says, cheerful, like she'd just finished another boring training tip as Adora instead of standing there as She-Ra, pristine despite her tumble in the dirt and her ancient magic sword in another woman's grasp, "I'm running another session tomorrow! If you come back for that we can work through some of the beats of the fight you just saw! Hope to see you there - if not, thanks for coming!"

Quidet stares at her for a moment longer, trying to figure out if she's...awkward or nervous or trying to get them out of there or in any way shaken. She has to come to the conclusion that either She-Ra's a really good actress or else she's just...not bothered. At all.

In a shocked daze, Quidet leaves with the rest of the students; she's halfway down the hall when she realizes that she didn't stop to tell She-Ra - Adora? - about her research. She debates it for a moment; she can always return to tomorrow's session, but - well, it is why she came in the first place, so she turns, pushes back through the wide-eyed, gossiping participants until she gets to the door. It's mostly but not fully closed, though through the trees Quidet can only see two pairs of legs, close together. There's voices coming from inside, and Quidet can't help but hear them as she goes to push it open further.

"—not be bothered by this!" It's Catra's voice, something like distraught and clearly on a tear.

Adora's reply doesn't match the intensity at all; a light non-sequitur, almost flippant. "I love you," she says.

Quidet freezes, tentacle on the doorknob that she thankfully hadn't yet pushed open. This isn't, she thinks, something she wants to interrupt, not if it's something private. Not if it's a *revelation;* not if she's stumbled onto something she shouldn't

have, something new and unexpected and so clearly festering between them for so much longer than—

"Yeah, I know." Nevermind that, then. Catra's response is distracted, annoyed, "Now can you stop being soppy for *half a second* and help me figure this out."

"I love you." The words are accompanied with the sound of rustling clothing, this time, as the legs press even closer together: a white-clad one sliding between two covered in dark leggings.

Quidet should leave.

Quidet doesn't leave.

Not even she hears, "Adora, this is serious! We don't know how the fuck this shit works!" A long, soft groan, and then, still coherent but halting, "What if...something is wrong with...your stupid She-Ra magic; if - mmm - *if someone* - if *someone else* can *manipulate* it, we— we— oh, *oh*, okay, that feels really nice - hey, no, can you *focus!"*

This time the words are even more muffled, murmured low and ardent: "I love you."

"Adora!" a thump Quidet identifies as hands-against-body, a few footsteps and shuffles and She-Ra's legs leave the sliver of forest-room visible, stumbling a few paces back, "Adora, quit it! I need you to help me figure this out."

There's a brief moment of silence, and then She-Ra's voice comes slow, and strong, and solid.

"*I. Love. You."*

A beat. And then, a different thump entirely, and Quidet sees through the crack as the Sword of Protection drops onto the ground.

Catra's voice follows, awestruck: "You love me."

"Thought you knew that, dummy." All the power's drained out of She-Ra's voice, leaving a teasing sweetness. Her legs come back into sight.

"You *love* me."

"Seriously, were you even listening to me? This isn't news."

"*You love me*."

"Really, Catra, we're going to have to clean out your ears with—*mmph*."

She's cut off abruptly, and then the only sounds are soft and breathy and not words at all.

And the thing is - you shouldn't meet your heroes, they'd said to Quidet, back when it had just been an abstract possibility.

It's not, anymore. In this moment, Quidet's hero is on the other side of this door, and she's seven feet tall but also five-foot-something, she's confident but also cocky but also nervous, she's maybe serious but certainly silly. She's petty and violent, trivial and competitive. She may, as the news reports, have sauntered out of the darkness carrying a celestial body in her wake, but that hasn't stopped her from dropping all her notecards on the floor of an artificial, alien forest. She's in love in a mundane, private way that makes Quidet viscerally homesick.

You should never meet your heroes, they'd said.

Tomorrow, Quidet decides, she'll prove them wrong.

For now, she steps back from the door, gently pulling it closed. The last thing she sees is the Sword of Protection, discarded there between two pairs of feet, as it dissipates absent-mindedly into particles of light.

Chapter End Notes

This is it, folks. I’ve finally meandered into point blank making up lore.

The final moment of this chapter has been wonderfully illustrated by Salineas; you can find that work here on tumblr and here on twitter.

While I am sharing social media, I will note that you can also follow me on tumblr at ostensiblyarticulate. I do not, however, make pretty art, so it's maybe less exciting.

BUT FIRST: Today, Intersystem Regional Leadership Convention, Elestia

Chapter Summary

[insert joke about captive audiences here]

Chapter Notes

last chapter not a drill have fun

See the end of the chapter for more notes

BUT FIRST

Today (+0 years), Intersystem Regional Leadership Convention, Elestia

"Are these seats free?"

Of course they're fucking free, Synest wants to say, though she keeps her head down. *You're really fucking early; why wouldn't they be free?*

She grunts instead. She figures that's answer enough, and indeed a shuffle of body and paper fills the seat directly in front of her, after which a bunch of cloth - a red jacket, a bag, a conference-issued notepad - is tossed onto a little square of three more seats, one next to the new girl and the other two in front of her.

No longer in danger of having to make conversation, Synest glances up to see a blonde ponytail swinging above a white, long-sleeved shirt, which is in turn stretched over broad shoulders and well-muscled arms that now move to rummage in a bag. Assured that ponytail-girl is otherwise engaged, Synest takes a moment to run a practiced eye over both the newcomer and her things: no weapons, overt or hidden, which is a good sign, but also nothing else much of interest; the shapes of her bag just as utilitarian and

unadorned as her clothing. There's a gold, wing-shaped pin on the belt she's got folded over her jacket in the seat beside her, and Synest does catch sight of some kind of alien technology tablet-pad-thing, but the latter has nothing to identify it as fancy and the former is pretty paltry, on its own.

Not this one, then. Ah well. Half the room is still unfilled; there's time. Synest is about to turn back to her own notepad of bored doodles when the ponytail swings its way around, suddenly replaced by a pair of earnest, blue-gray eyes.

"This is the intro session on planetary defense systems, right? I got kind of turned around outside."

A quick assessment of Ponytail's front side turns up nothing new, at least from a business standpoint. From a less professional perspective...well, she's nice to look at, with a sweet, bright grin that makes even the weirdly poofy bit of blonde above her forehead seem endearing rather than strange. And if this location *is* a bust, Synest is about to have a free night. It's that along with the memory of this girl's shoulders from the back that have Synest forming her own slow, suggestive smirk. "You're in the right place," she murmurs, letting her eyes trail ostentatiously up and then back down. She briefly mourns how plain she knows she looks right now - no jewelry to speak of, head covered by a black cap because this is technically a *low-profile-you're-working* sort of day, not a *pick-up-girls* sort - but she knows full well that force of personality can carry her, if it must. She puts a little extra of that into it as she does her best to purr, "and I sure am glad you found it."

"Me too!" Ponytail sighs her exasperation with her entire body, grin getting somehow wider, "There are *so many* staircases in here, and no signs *at all*, so how am I supposed to know which one's the south one? I mean, I'm a pretty good tracker, if I do say so myself, but big buildings like this don't really give me much to work with, you know? But like, throw me in the wilderness, and *pshh*, it's fine, I'm your girl."

Synest blinks a bit at the onslaught of words, but rallies, leaning forward and lowering her voice to ask, “Oh, are you?”

Ponytail blinks back, “Uh...yeah?” She says. Her eyebrows draw together, and Synest isn’t sure if she’s going for coy or simply perplexed.

Synest figures the best way to find out is to ask. She leans even more into Ponytail’s space to murmur smoothly, “If that’s so, and if you’re free—”

“Thank *fuck*!”

Synest *jumps*.

She shakes herself a little, barely taking note of the blush on Ponytail’s face as she berates herself for getting so distracted. Then, she turns her attention to the interruption: it’s not the first person who’s walked in the door since Ponytail sat down, but this one - a whirl of glitter and pink and lavender with a gold tiara, followed by a young man in a gold-edged, midriff-baring, *useless*-looking armor-shirt-thing - is certainly the loudest. She’s also the first attendee to really draw Synest’s attention in a professional sense. Between the gems casually placed at the girl’s ear and forehead and throat, the total lack of concern at the volume of her entrance, the *cape*, and...is *that a fucking scepter*? Because it looks like a fucking scepter pretending to be a staff, of all the *pretenstions* - well. Between all of it, Synest’s pretty damn sure she’s found her mark.

Which makes it all the more interesting when Tiara-and-Earring flounces over to the chairs in front of Ponytail, huffily shoving the various possessions on them back into the blonde’s lap as she files in. She all but throws herself down into the seat as the Bare-Midriff-Boy slips more sedately into the one beside her. He props a full quiver and bow beside his chair, but the bow is gold, too, so Synest is inclined against thinking he knows how to use it.

Synest smothers her triumph, but she'd really like to laugh. Fuck *yeah.* This, *this* is why you go to the stupid fucking *Intro to Interplanatary Defense* session. Because where *else* are the just-in-town-for-a-convention, mommy's-at-the-important-meetings, too-minor-for-a-competent-security-detail-but-sure-major-enough-to-for-a-ransom politicians' kids gonna go, at an event like this?

"Who even *runs* this thing?!" Tiara is all but shouting, every inch the brat Synest guessed. "What kind of event has *no signs* absolutely *anywhere!?"*

Midriff leans over to Ponytail to say ruefully, "She almost got in a fight with a staffer."

Ponytail laughs at that. "At least *you* could find someone to fight! I wasn't even sure I made it to the right place, though I know it's right because— Oh, uh," she turns to Synest, blushing again, "I didn't catch your—"

"Alright, let's get started!" the session leader announces, and Ponytail shoots Synest an apologetic smile before turning attentively to the presentation. As soon as she turns around, Synest breathes a carefully silent sigh of relief. *Good timing*, she thinks, slumping in her seat with her best impression of a bored attendee in the back, someone no one would give a second glance. Once situated, she reaches into the inside pocket of her coat for the Device. Her fingers meet cool metal, and she finds by feel the switch on the side, flicking it on-and-off briefly. They haven't much figured out what it does otherwise - besides being small enough to fit in her coat, which is nice, and turning up right next to a cave-hidden door no one can open, which isn't - but it does have a unique signal when she does *this*, and she knows her team will be at the ready once they intercept it.

A loud beeping noise makes Synest jerk to attention, and the rest of the room turns to glare at Ponytail, who's frantically fumbling with her tech pad to make it stop. She blushes bright red as she stammers out her apologies, and it's cute, and Synest briefly mourns the evening she no longer has time to ask for. Ah well.

Maybe Ponytail here is the type to get hot for a show of force - it wouldn't be the first time a mark was into it, once Synest made it clear the goal was a ransom with minimal violence. She could get lucky.

Real lucky, she thinks, gazing idly at those shoulders again as the lecture restarts. View aside, it's boring. She'd usually use this time to plan her operation, but these three are so *easy* - she's sure she can waylay them just long enough to make sure they leave last, and by then the fake detour will be up and a crew of ten will be ready to ambush the alley it'll take them down. Beyond that: disarm the boy, really, that's her plan, because it's not like Tiara over there's gonna put up much of a fight, and Synest is pretty sure Ponytail's build has gotta be from her weird wilderness hobby. Easy, easy, easy.

The only downside is that without much to plan, Synest is *bored.* She entertains herself mostly by watching the swing of Ponytail's ponytail and the play of the muscles on her back as she takes notes and as she - and oh, this is adorable - *raises her hand* to ask a question. Maybe she doesn't even like Tiara and Midriff, Synest imagines. Maybe she thinks they're real, real obnoxious, and she'd be *very grateful* to someone who shut them up for a while. *So grateful*, even, that she'd want to make her gratefulness known. That could be fun.

Synest doesn't even notice when, ten minutes into the session, the door opens to admit another attendee, but her ignorance doesn't last long. The new presence asserts itself first as a shadow, which falls over Synest's seat sinisterly, then the glint of light off the sharp tip of a claw. The claw - and once Synest catches sight of it, she really can't look away - carves not-lightly-enough through the very top layer of the wood at the edge of Synest's desk, the scraping sound of it subtle and threatening under the drone of the lecture.

Synest's eyes snap up to see a woman with short, unruly hair and soft-looking pointed ears, who pulls her claw languidly away when Synest meets her glare.

"Whoops," the woman murmurs in a low voice. She flashes a mouth full of fangs even as she says with utter insincerity, "Didn't see you there."

At her voice, Ponytail turns in her seat. Her face does a strangely compelling little dance that starts with a bright smile and ends with a dark glare. "*Finally*," she hisses, glancing at the front of the rest of the room with clear concern that she might be disturbing the other attendees, "*where have you been?*"

Claws turns that fanged smile on Ponytail, but now it looks more genuine. "Here, there. Y'know." She slides past Ponytail to take the seat next to her, using the movement to rub against her more than entirely necessary. The new woman's long, furred tail follows her path and then lingers to drape across Ponytail's lap, even as Claws sits down. She also uses the movement to meet Synest's eyes again, which - yeah, Synest gets the message.

And Synest is pissed, yeah. Not over the girl - it's fine, whatever, there are other girls - but over the rudeness, the display. But sure, Synest can let that go too, in the name of not making a scene, in the name of bigger plans. The bigger issue is: Ponytail, Midriff, Tiara, they're easy. This one? Synest's eyes linger on the way the woman's claws tap against the wood of her newly acquired desk. This one's more of a problem.

In front of her, Ponytail also seems to have a problem, because she's looking at Claws with narrowed eyes. "*Oh, so you got lost,*" she whispers, accusatory.

"Did not," Claws replies, too loud. One of the attendees at the front glances back, and Ponytail makes an apologetic gesture, glaring at Claws and mouthing an exaggerated *did too.* Claws pauses for a moment, eyes darting from the front row and back to the girl beside her. She cocks her head. "Thought I'd—" Ponytail shushes her, and she huffs, restarting slightly quieter, though with no less bite. "Thought I'd find you in the front row, all bright-eyed and bushy-tailed. What, you get in trouble?"

"No," Ponytail faces the front again primly, but makes no motion to dislodge the tail still in her lap. "*I just knew you'd be late*."

Claws leans in closer, fully invading the other woman's space. She's grinning that toothy grin again, and this time Synest is almost certain it isn't for show. "Aww, it's almost like you like me."

Ponytail does a little hand-clench head-tilt thing at the proximity. Synest watches Ponytail try to focus forward on the lecture, watches her fail, though she doesn't turn to the woman next to her. She does hiss out of the corner of her mouth, "*No idea what gives you that impression. Now shh, he's talking*."

Claws, clearly satisfied with the reaction she's elicited, slumps in her seat, digging a claw idly into a groove in her desk. She seems to be intent on paying about as much attention to the lecture as Synest is, which is to say none at all.

Bodyguard? Synest thinks - but no, there was too much intimacy in her exchange with Ponytail, and from the way she seemed to delight in flustering the blonde, Synest is pretty sure she knows which of the pair is in charge. Not to mention the bored petulance Claws slides into as the session goes on, which doesn't especially speak to any kind of training or duty or, really, shits given at all. *Girlfriend*, she thinks instead, and then - comparing Claws' slouch to Ponytail's straight-backed attentiveness, putting the gold pin on the latter's belt in context of Ponytail's glittering-and-gold other friends - amends it to *unsuitable girlfriend.*

Synest becomes more certain as the session progresses. Tiara interrupts the speaker quickly with questions, all loud and abrasive inquiries into *magic* of all things - head-in-the-clouds, storybook fare that has no place in a serious conversation, all with the entitled tone of a woman who doesn't care that she's wasting other people's time. She's left fuming when the speaker shuts her down firmly, and Midriff leans over to placate her while Ponytail speaks out instead, focusing her inquiries on items that are more grounded if still irrelevant, tangents about Horde Prime's recent rule (messy, hands off, more a base than a conquest) and the

ancient culture that settled the planet at least a thousand years before (pretty much entirely irrelevant to day-to-day operations - to put it mildly - and even less relevant to *defense systems*). They're the questions, Synest decides, of a very good student who is eager to show off what she knows from her books, and the obnoxiousness of it makes Synest a bit less disappointed that she won't be taking this woman home, at least not like *that.* Synest has different plans for the afternoon starting to form, and they don't involve any attempts to seduce this woman away from her clearly dangerous lover.

The dangerous lover who, Synest decides, she'll have to take out first. She can't call off the operation - the Device's signal is a one-way kind of thing, and fuck if she isn't going to need something more complex than that in the future - but she wouldn't even if she could. This new woman is formidable, but not impossible. Not even the worst Synest has dealt with, what with her typical marks' propensity for bodyguards and undercover bodyguards and surprise security details. None of those to worry about, here. Still, Claws will have to go down first, before the quartet recognizes any sign of danger; Synest will do it herself. One quick, sharp blow from the back with Synest's dagger; not a death-blow, maybe, but also not a problem if there's some damage. Claws is an obstacle, not the goal.

Most likely, by the time the other three notice their more capable companion down, it'll be too late - Synest's crew will be on them. She probably won't even have to direct them on disarming Midriff - in close range and with surprise on their side, anyone would know to snip the string on that fancy bow - and Ponytail should be easy enough to overwhelm with numbers. Synest barely even spares a thought for Tiara; the most they'll probably have to keep track of with her is stopping her from screaming.

And then it's simply a matter of taking them somewhere secure, threatening or cajoling or - if Synest is lucky, she supposes - flirting out information on the identity of someone with money who would give a shit that they're gone. A few well-encrypted calls and a drop point later, and yeah. Ta-da. Success.

There are worse ways to make a living, Synest thinks.

She sits back to wait.

—

The operation goes perfectly, until it doesn't.

Synest doesn't even have to make sure her quarry is the last to leave, since the quartet stays back to pester the speaker, and by the time they actually exit the room all the other attendees have long since scattered. They stop to confer with each other briefly in quiet voices, then fall easily for the old fake-detour-sign routine, cheerfully willing to believe that the subsequent presentations have been moved to an alternative building. Tiara even enthusiastically praises the existence of "*actual signs, finally!"* as they turn down a series of increasingly remote - but, crucially, well signposted - alleyways.

Synest tails them quietly; as they approach the right spot she pulls up her mask and pulls out her dagger. She waits until they turn down the alley where she knows her crew is waiting in the shadows. She's even lucky enough that Claws has fallen a touch behind the rest, scraping her clawed fingers lightly along the wall of the alleyway while the other three argue loudly over where to get lunch. They make it around the corner and Synest sneaks in close to peer around, tracks them for three...two...one...

Synest leaps—

She gets close.

She gets so, so close, right up to the shorter woman's waiting, unprotected back. Synest's dagger is a wicked point, barely brushing the place between the woman's ribs, one breath from sliding in, and—

Claws doesn't move. She doesn't turn, she doesn't flinch. She might as well not have noticed Synest at all, for all she reacts to the attack. And yet, one moment Synest is lunging forward out of the shadows, and the next she's flat against the wall of the alley, back stinging from the impact and the heavy weight of a long pole - gold, she sees from the corner of her eye, and where the *fuck* did that come from - holding her hard in place. In front of her is Ponytail, looking very serious and not surprised at all.

Okay, so maybe there is *a bodyguard*, Synest thinks, doing new mental math at the firm, unrelenting strength of Ponytail's hold. She tries to turn, but finds that the weight of the pole leaves no room for movement at all. She tries to kick, and Ponytail simply moves her weight to Synest's neck, cutting off her air for just a moment as she says levelly, "Drop it."

Synest stops kicking and - when a moment passes and the pressure doesn't let up - drops her knife. It clatters to the ground as the pressure relents and Synest gasps, looking past her captor to lock her eyes on Claws and snarl, "Call off your fucking guard dog."

Claws turns her head, now, a casual movement. She doesn't look shaken, or concerned, not the way anyone *should* look when a moment before a dagger was a scale's-width from their insides, though she does look a little surprised, blinking slowly at Synest's voice.

Then, she starts laughing. And laughing, and laughing, like Synest just told a joke. She's doubled-over, nearly crying with it before she catches her breath, taking deep pulls of air and breaking off into occasional chuckles, wiping at her eyes. She takes a step toward Synest, still smiling a fang-laden grin like this is the funniest thing she's experienced all day as she darts in so close that her face crowds out even Ponytail's. She says, cheerfully, "Call off yours."

"Actually, we're good," comes a voice from the further down the alley, and all three of them - Synest and Claws and Ponytail - turn

to see Tiara and Midriff and a blue-and-red feline creature that Synest has *never seen before,* and absolutely none of Synest's crew. Except her crew *is* there, she realizes after a moment, *every single fucking one* of them (she counts, goddamnit, *every one*) unconscious on the ground, Midriff's bow and Tiara's staff held in clear post-combat position.

"Huh. Never mind then." Claws says, shrugging. She takes a step back, giving Synest only the briefest, most dismissive glance before she looks back to Ponytail. Her words are deliberate, sharp and certain but still somehow unabashedly deferential when she asks, "So, what's the plan?"

Ponytail turns to flash Claws a smile, and Synest feels the balance of power shift. Except maybe she doesn't - maybe it was always like that, because when Ponytail speaks it's with the assurance that only can come with a bone-deep confidence that she'll be listened to. She says, "Glimmer, Melog, do a sweep; we don't want any more unwelcome guests. Bow, take a look at that tech - if it's First Ones stuff, that could be the clue we need."

Midriff - Bow, presumably, which is kind of on-the-nose - lowers his bow and arrow to cast Ponytail a confused look. "Uh...we didn't get the tech yet?"

Ponytail snorts. "Sure we did. Catra swiped it when she was all up in our friend's face."

Synest realizes that *our friend* means her the same time Claws-whose-name-is-actually-Catra, feral grin even wider, pulls Synest's Device out from the waistband of her pants. She tosses it in the air and catches it. "Wha—" Synest starts, knowing she looks shocked and unable to hide the reaction because *she didn't notice that at all*, what the *fuck.*

They ignore her, because Catra's grin is firmly directed at Ponytail, and her voice is somewhere between squeaky-pleased and a purr when says gleefully, "You *noticed!"*

"I always notice where your hands are," Ponytail says, then flushes red as the words catch up with her. "That is— I mean—"

Catra is laughing uproariously again and Ponytail's still stammering and Bow is grinning and the woman apparently named Glimmer (or Melog, but she *looks* like a Glimmer) is chuckling, so it *should be* the perfect moment for Synest to slither free. And she tries, she does, but either embarrassment doesn't distract Ponytail as much as it appears or she's even stronger than Synest had realized, because the blonde woman doesn't budge, doesn't even seem to notice Synest's squirming.

Catra tosses the Device to Bow, who lowers his bow to catch it one-handed. He holds it up to eye level to examine all sides of it, humming thoughtfully, then very tentatively and seriously touches its metal surface with his tongue.

"Ew!" Glimmer hisses, "That's *gross*, you don't know where that's been!"

"Says the dumbass who kisses him," Catra drawls.

Synest can no longer see where the shorter woman is, but can fully imagine the prissy, aristocratic nose-scrunch that would accompany her reply of, "Not after *that* I don't."

"Definitely First Ones tech," Bow announces, ignoring them. "Which doesn't necessarily mean anything, Etheria has First Ones stuff all over—"

"Yeah, but we usually recognize it," Catra replies, "or at least people who give a shit like Entrapta and Hordak and Bow's weird nerdy dads do. None of the scientists here ever saw any before we turned up, and none of those *defense experts*," she scoffs, "did either. That's probably why they're all okay with us fucking around with it; they don't think we'll find anything to fuck with."

"It would make sense for the tech to be pretty localized," Ponytail notes, turning to look at the rest of her team (though not, a

frustrated Synest notices yet again, slackening her grip). "This place didn't register especially high on the Magic-o-Meter—"

"Magic-o-Meter?" Catra cuts in flatly. "That really what we're going with?"

"Hey, I like Magic-o-Meter!" Bow looks affronted.

Glimmer's voice carries over with, "It's a very nice name, Bow, you're very good at naming."

"It really isn't, it's super stu—"

"*Shut up*, Catra!"

"*Point is*," Catra says, clearly not shutting up. "We're probably looking for just one area of First Ones tech, so we just gotta find it, free it - you *do* have the whole sure-go-free-the-magic-whatever authorization in writing, right, Sparkles?"

"Of *course* I do. What do you think I am, *stupid?*"

"Well, considering *last time*—"

Bow cuts in with, "Okay, but the thing I'm stuck on is finding it. Because sure, this," he holds up the device, "is First Ones tech, but it's not like it's got a label saying where it came from. How are we supposed to figure that out?"

"Good question," Ponytail says, cocking her head at Synest.

Synest isn't sure she wants to tell.

For one, she didn't follow any of that, so she has no idea what she'd be party to if she did. Not to mention she's here in this remote alley with her crew quite thoroughly out of commission, outarmed and outnumbered, stripped of her weapon and reduced to the hope that these four aren't the type to dispose of their informants after the informing. And Ponytail's grip is as firm as ever, and Catra behind her is making a very ostentatious show of

examining her very, very sharp claws, and Synest is having vivid flashbacks to the very new grooves in the wood of the desk she'd been sitting at just fifteen minutes prior.

(This is around when Synest realizes she's panicking. She is, she thinks, entitled to panic.)

Something of all this must show on her face, because, "Catra," Ponytail says over her shoulder, "tell her we're not going to hurt her."

"What? Why me?"

"*Because*, you're the one everyone *always* thinks is going to hurt them."

Catra splutters, "Excuse *you*, I am—"

"You do it on *purpose."*

Catra's mouth opens and closes for a moment, and then she sighs. She turns to Synest, and when she speaks it's far more earnest than Synest would have expected. "Look, we're not going to hurt you," she says. "Not if you don't talk, not if you do, and not *after* you do. But we want to…help. So just...tell us where you got the thing and we'll get out of your hair."

Synest doesn't have hair, but she doesn't mention that. Especially since Glimmer stands up from where she's tying up one of Synest's team, narrows her eyes and leans on her scepter-staff-thing. Synest notices a smear of blood on it, right under the gemstone top, and the look she gives Synest across it is terrifyingly savage. "Unless you—"

"*Glimmer!"* The admonishment comes from both Ponytail and Bow.

"*Unless*," Glimmer presses on, uncowed, "you send us into a trap. That shit doesn't work anymore: we *will* get out and we *will* come haunt you."

“Oh, right,” Bow says, almost to himself, clearly realizing the motivation behind his companion’s caveat, “Crimson Waste.”

“Crimson Waste,” Catra drawls, flicking up fingers in a count, “Princess Prom, that time in Elberon, technically I’d say Salineas counts, Prime’s ship…”

Ponytail doesn’t so much roll her eyes as rolls her whole head, this time, “You are *not* helping our case. And anyway, *you* were behind half of those, and that’s different.”

Synest doesn’t even try to parse that one. Not that she’d have time to, because a moment later, Glimmer is saying, “*Anyway*, *point is:* traps are an absolute—”

“Actually,” Ponytail interrupts, “I have an idea about that.” She turns back to Synest. She cocks her head in a way that sets her ponytail swinging, and smiles a slow, confident, *smug* smile. “Any chance you’re free tonight?”

—

She asks Synest one more thing, before she goes. That one comes later, at the end of the world’s most bizarre (though strangely informative) field trip, in a hidden cavern Synest has seen once before but never been able to enter. Synest is gasping for breath as they all - the six of them, four bipedal alien strangers and one apparently shapeshifting sometimes-invisible alien cat and Synest herself - sprawl on a tech-laden floor beside an arcane, now-broken machine and the corpse of a some eldritch worm-monster the like of which Synest could never have imagined. The sharp, wicked point of Synest’s dagger is buried deep in its gut, and its still-warm, dark green blood is on her hands. Ponytail is on her ass on the floor, inexplicably two feet taller and glowing and covered in monster-spit, exactly in the spot where the creature had just tried to snap its jaws.

She shoots Synest a wide, casual grin. “Thanks!” she says, and she looks sort of giddy, and Synest is giddy, too - maybe from the near-death adrenaline, but Synest thinks it’s something else, something that broke free in the moments when Bow and Catra and Glimmer had taken advantage of the monster’s distraction to destroy that machine where it whirred, a tingling pulse that makes everything suddenly feel a little more possible. Synest grins back at the blonde - though her ponytail is more gold than blonde, now - and climbs to her feet; she cleans off her hands with the tatters of her cap before she offers Ponytail a hand up. Ponytail takes it easily, though a thoughtful frown crosses her face, and she asks, “Hey, that whole *thing* you’re into, with the stabbing people in alleys and all - you’re not going to do that anymore, right?”

And - it’s not mind control, what happens then. It some strange way, it’s kind of the opposite. Synest isn’t even sure Ponytail knows what she’s done, the sudden weight that seems to fall on her question and - more than that - on Synest’s pending answer.

Because there are those eyes again, the same ones that Synest had taken for naive and sweet in that little cramped conference room, back when she’d somehow missed the sharpness there, the steel. They’re the same, but they’re also different, this time, still earnest and kind and bright and blue but now a different blue, a shocking, *magic* blue, and—

Synest isn’t small-town, not exactly, she’s seen a galaxy or two. But for the first time, she thinks she can see the whole universe. It is brilliant and glittering, bursting with wonder, and vaster than Synest should be able to comprehend. Except Synest *can* comprehend it, just for a flash, and in that flash she knows with inexplicable certainty that she can *move* it, in all its vastness, for better or for worse.

Synest blinks, and just like that it’s gone. But there’s an afterimage there, like walking into the dark after too much time in the light, and it makes Synest *want*.

And there’s a girl in front of her, waiting for an answer.

“No, uh. Of course not,” Synest stammers. She could make it a lie, of course, but that doesn’t occur to her for a long, long time.

(And later still, that day, a blonde girl with a ponytail makes her way up the ramp of a spaceship.

“Does it look different to you?” Her girlfriend asks, eyeing the landscape around them. “It doesn’t look different to me.”

“I think it’s...brighter, maybe?” Bow’s reply is uncertain, “I could be making that up.”

There’s a burst of magic from beside them. “It sure feels different,” Glimmer announces over Catra’s surprised yelp, then disappears as fast as she’d appeared, avoiding a clawed swipe.

“Oh, I’ll give you different!” Catra shouts nonsensically, bolting into the ship with Melog at her heels, and Bow casts Adora an exasperated glance before speeding up after them. Adora leaves them to it, stopping in the ship’s entryway. She leans there against Darla’s hull, looking out at a planet they’ve only barely visited - this place is purple, mostly, with lavender foliage and bright orange flowers and an abundance of some bioluminescent bug, and since they landed on a high bluff it means that Adora can see the bustle of the town that sits at its base. Bow’s right, it *is* brighter, though she doesn’t know if that’s something she can see or something she can feel. She simply knows it’s there, and that it’s magic, and that it’s pleased.

She stands there until she feels warmth along her back and arms around her waist, a tail curling around her leg and a sharp chin digging into her shoulder.

“What are you thinking about?” Catra asks, playful and low.

“Do you think they’ll be okay?” Adora asks back.

That gets a snort in her ear. “They better be, after all that. You’re not gonna smell right for a week.” Catra pauses a moment, but then she adds, “Okay, what are you actually thinking about?”

Adora huffs, caught. “She-Ra.”

“Ah, something different for you.”

“She won’t be around forever, is all.”

Adora knows it’s wrong as soon as she says it. Catra goes tense at her back, and her voice goes raw and thin, like all the breath has been knocked out of her. “Ado—”

“No, no.” Adora rushes the words, “No. Not like that.”

She cranes her head back over her shoulder and smiles into her girlfriend’s mouth when Catra lets herself be pulled into a languid, reassuring kiss - one that Adora, in turn, lets go on for far too long. She gets a little lost in it, and when they part it takes her a moment of closeness, of feeling the warmth of Catra’s breath on her face and watching the sweep of each individual eyelash, recounting each freckle, before she remembers her train of thought.

“I...maybe Etheria will pick someone else, but...I won’t plan a life for some stranger I’ve never met. And I’m not immortal, Catra.” She adds, moving to cover Catra’s hands with her own. “None of us are. I wouldn’t want us to be. That was Prime’s whole thing, remember? *Eternal light*, blah blah blah, *I’m the most important in the universe*, blah blah blah, *bow down and listen to every version of me*. She-Ra...She-Ra could do that. And I won’t.”

Catra sighs at that. She buries her face into Adora’s shoulder more firmly, nipping at the skin there in a way that says she doesn’t disagree but also doesn’t want to say as much out loud.

Glimmer teleports her way beside them, and they both jump - without parting, as a unit rather than separately. “What won’t you do? Is it ditch Catra, because I can help.” She asks.

Adora shifts to look at Glimmer without breaking Catra's grip, catching as she does the languid, malice-less way Catra sticks out her tongue. Adora grins, bringing one hand up behind her head to scratch at Catra's ear in an unnecessary *you're not going anywhere*, which gets her a purr. What she says out loud is, "I'm just thinking," Glimmer gives her a quizzical look, so she keeps going. "We should set up training, or something. Like, something explaining what the First Ones did, and sharing what we've learned, tips, stuff like that. What magic even is, for places like this—"

"How to use it," Bow adds, joining their little cluster at Darla's entry. "Etheria was ready for a burst of new magic, we all were already handling so much of it, but this place...let's just say I've been giving out our contact signal like candy."

Glimmer looks thoughtful. "...not everyone's gonna like all that," she notes, addressing Adora's suggestion.

Adora shrugs, "That's fine. Hey, maybe they shouldn't, even. It's not like we know what's best for everyone. But we can give them…"

"...a choice." Catra says, voice strong at Adora's ear. She steps out from behind Adora to look at her, though she keeps hold of Adora's hand.

They think together, the four of them, for a quiet moment. And then:

"Adora...that's a lot." Glimmer says, "Like, a lot a lot."

"Was always going to be, though," Bow says, "I asked Entrapta once - the number of planets the First Ones and Prime hit…it's scary big*."*

And Catra says, "It'll take a long time."

Longer than we have, Adora thinks, and it's an unpleasant thought. Because Adora can feel it - the universe - all the time:

ever-shifting and immense and insurmountable, all around her and also somehow looming endlessly at the edges of She-Ra's senses the way a mountain looms on the horizon, more incomprehensible the closer it gets. It is a universe filled with latent magic incalculable, thrumming with unsatisfied longing like this planet was just this morning; a clamoring mass of too many strange galaxies and even more strange planets, with incessant tests to press upon her shoulders and every kind of monster and *so many* aliens—

—like a woman, today, who put her dagger between Adora and a monster, who freed her own planet's magic despite waking up this morning with far different plans. And maybe Adora will never see her again, but even if she doesn't, Adora thinks, there are others like her. There are people at home rebuilding Etheria and on other planets picking up their own pieces, there's the Princess Alliance and the people of Plumeria and the Star Siblings, and Wrong Hordak and the new-freed clones and this planet's Council that had debated all week before providing permission to free its magic and this girl today with her sharp little dagger and everyone else Adora has yet to meet.

Longer than we have - it's an unpleasant thought, and then it isn't. Because on this cliff on this alien planet, with her friends beside her and magic around her and the whole universe out before her, full as it is, Adora feels - suddenly and completely and certainly - the least alone she ever has in her life.

"Well then," she says, beaming, "I guess we'd better start.")

Chapter End Notes

I lied, a little. I said at the beginning of this fic that the first and last chapters would be about the BFS as a whole, and to some degree that is true. But in many ways, this is Adora's story, and it turned out she wanted her say here at the

beginning of it. She is, as I hope this chapter demonstrated, hard to deny.

Thanks to everyone who made it all the way through; this was a joy to write (most of the time), but I really do miss getting to hang out in the actual POV BRAINS of my faves, so I'll be going back to that now.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!